

THE ECONOMIC TIMES

wealth

Metro to small town?

The money math of moving out. **P2**



PAY HIKE VS TAKE-HOME **P10** | EXPENSE TRACKING APPS ARE CHANGING HOW INDIANS INVEST **P14**

Should you quit your metro?

Many Indians are trading metro salaries for the sanity of smaller cities. Before you join them, find out what the move actually means for your finances.

by Riju Mehta

For Sheel Jaitley, 42, it was a no-brainer. Her son suffered frequent wheezing and nasal congestion in Bengaluru, where he was born in 2016, but recovered magically every time she visited her family in Manipal, a suburb of Udupi in coastal Karnataka. For the high-flying city-hopper with a successful corporate career, the decision was well-considered but inevitable. In 2024, the family moved from Bengaluru to Manipal. Jaitley's income took a hit after she left her job and launched an ed-tech startup, Fuggae. Her husband, a Securities and Exchange Board of India (Sebi)-registered investment adviser, travels frequently between Delhi and Manipal. Still, Jaitley is happy with the trade-off. "It's cleaner, greener, safer, with fewer health issues, and no traffic or societal pressure to maintain a fancy lifestyle. We also don't have to wait till Diwali to meet the family," she says.

It's a transition many in the metros dream of, but seldom make because the decision to relocate often rests on the fragile balance between the quality of life and cost of living, between income and expenses, priorities and trade-offs. The draw of a lucrative job, career options, and top-tier medical, educational, and public infrastructure in metros weighs against the need for a pollution-, traffic-, and stress-free life in a tier 2 city. So far, the balance has remained largely skewed, with the eight metros and tier 1 cities (Delhi, Mumbai, Chennai, Kolkata, Bengaluru, Hyderabad,



Ahmedabad, Pune) preferred over the tier 2 cities. The skew may have shifted a bit now. "While top cities continue to remain the largest economic engines, some tier 2 cities have evolved into well-established regional hubs driven by augmented infrastructure, connectivity and business activity," says Ankita Sood, National Director, Research, Knight Frank India. "Lucknow, Kochi, Chandigarh, Jaipur, Indore, Bhubaneswar, Goa and Coimbatore, among others, con-

tinue to stand out due to improving connectivity, expanding economic ecosystems and strengthening social infrastructure, all of which are contributing positively to the overall liveability," she adds. For 39-year-old Vaibhav Jain, who shifted from Bengaluru to Indore last year after "quitting the corporate rat race", the decision was imminent. "I was very sure I wanted to shift to a tier 2 city and the

move was expedited when my daughter was born," says Jain, whose income has come down 40-50% ever since he shifted and started his own venture. "If my venture doesn't take off in 2-3 years, I'm flexible about moving back to a metro," he says, despite enjoying all the perks of a small city—lower expenses, lesser pollution, and more time with the family. The fall in earning capacity in a tier 2 city is often the deciding factor for many who

Quality of life & cost of living: Metro vs tier 2



Quality of life index				Cost of living			
Metro/ tier 1	Index value	Tier 2	Index value	Metro/ tier 1	Cost (per month)	Tier 2	Cost (per month)
Hyderabad	176.46	Bhubaneswar	143.40	Mumbai	₹2.4 lakh	Kochi	₹97,000
Pune	166.30	Surat	142.67	Bengaluru	₹1.4 lakh	Chandigarh	₹94,000
Chennai	140.68	Coimbatore	136.17	Delhi	₹1.2 lakh	Surat	₹88,000
Bengaluru	137.69	Jaipur	135.27	Pune	₹1.1 lakh	Coimbatore	₹84,000
Ahmedabad	133.13	Kochi	126.46	Chennai	₹1.1 lakh	Indore	₹83,000
Kolkata	109.53	Indore	125.69	Hyderabad	₹99,000	Jaipur	₹77,000
Delhi	88.78	Lucknow	114.97	Kolkata	₹87,000	Bhubaneswar	₹72,000
Mumbai	87.05	Chandigarh	NA	Ahmedabad	₹85,000	Lucknow	₹68,000



Sources: Numbeo, Cost-of-livingindia.com. Data sites are crowdsourced. Figures/values are indicative and could vary. Figures are rounded off. Quality of life index takes into account various parameters like cost of living, purchasing power, housing affordability, pollution, healthcare, traffic, and crime rate. Cost of living for a family with kids includes 3-BHK rent in city centre, dining, groceries, utilities, transport, household help, shopping, lifestyle & entertainment and miscellaneous spends. Tier 2 cities chosen randomly.



Property rates, rents lower in tier 2 cities

	Metro/tier 1			Tier 2			Loan affordability Index
	Cost (per sq m)	Rent (per month)	Loan affordability Index	Cost (per sq m)	Rent (per month)	Loan affordability Index	
Mumbai	₹6,34,550	₹1,92,000	0.29	Chandigarh	₹2,17,731	₹40,000	0.51
Delhi	₹2,40,286	₹68,000	0.55	Indore	₹1,23,721	₹36,000	0.66
Pune	₹2,11,557	₹59,000	1.3	Bhubaneswar	₹1,16,243	₹30,000	0.76
Bengaluru	₹1,70,622	₹81,000	1.27	Coimbatore	₹1,16,111	₹30,000	0.74
Chennai	₹1,65,175	₹41,000	1.02	Lucknow	₹1,11,528	₹33,000	0.82
Hyderabad	₹1,30,635	₹53,000	2.14	Kochi	₹1,02,257	₹37,000	0.78
Kolkata	₹1,10,165	₹38,000	0.91	Jaipur	₹77,859	₹35,000	1.11
Ahmedabad	₹81,391	₹42,000	1.32	Surat	₹66,067	₹39,000	1.19

Source: Numbeo. In loan affordability index, higher values indicate better affordability. Rent is for a 3-BHK apartment in city centre. Data site is crowdsourced. Figures are indicative and could vary. Some figures are rounded off.

are otherwise strongly inclined to embrace a better quality of life. Here are some factors to consider before deciding to relocate.

Career growth & future income

It's important to consider your career stage while deciding to make a shift. For early-stage professionals, it's best to explore opportunities in tier 1 cities and move to tier 2/3 cities only after gaining experience. "In the very early stages of a career, tier 1 cities have an edge over tier 2/3 cities because you learn through peers, mentors, leaders, friends, and the entire ecosystem is set for you to learn and grow practically on a daily basis," says Neeti Sharma, CEO, TeamLease Digital.

If career growth is a priority, you will need to make a calculated, informed decision. "If moving to a smaller city reduces visibility, your career will suffer. The main reason for a slowdown is not geography, but professional isolation. To maintain momentum, you will need to keep your top relationships active, stay visible on LinkedIn and company events, and take on impactful work," says Devashish Chakravarty, Founder, QVerify, an employee background verification firm, and a regular *ET Wealth* columnist.

Jaitley knows it well. "My networking has suffered because it takes a hit outside metros, especially if you are launching a startup and require funding as well."

Sharma has a counter view. "Career growth today is becoming more skill-based than just city-based, especially in roles across tech, finance, human resources and analytics. What matters is the skills and value one brings to the table," she says.

What also matters is the fewer opportunities available in tier 2 cities. "One of the biggest challenges is the lack of job opportunities in Chandigarh, especially in the IT sector," says 40-year-old Akashdeep Garg, a data engineer-turned-financial adviser, who moved to Chandigarh in 2022. His wife, Rohita, still travels to Gurugram for one week every month. "She's working in the hybrid mode, but if she switches to a Chandigarh-based company, she might need to compromise on the hike," he adds.

If you are considering self-employment,



Anuj & Simran Kesarwani, 35 & 29
Financial planners

Relocation

Navi Mumbai

to Prayagraj in 2026

Benefits

- Lower pollution, better food quality.
- Higher interaction with family, friends.

Drawbacks

- Medical infrastructure better in metros.
- Professional networking impacted.

Fall in income 10-20%

Fall in expenses 30-40%

“It's difficult to afford a house before marriage in a metro and the quality of life in a tier 2 city is much better.”

Vaibhav & Aditi Jain
39 & 36

Entrepreneur & homemaker

Relocation

Bengaluru

to Indore in 2025

Benefits

- Better quality of life.
- More time with family.

Drawbacks

- Fall in income due to a startup.
- Professional interaction reduced.

Fall in income 40-50%

Fall in expenses 10-20%

“If my venture doesn't take off in another 2-3 years, I'm flexible about moving back to a metro.”



it will require not only networking but also better financial preparation, with a 6-12 month cash-flow contingency to sustain your lifestyle while incubating a new venture. "Expect 30-50% income volatility immediately after you switch to self-employed or remote work. As you stabilise your income pipeline, the volatility can reduce to 20% over a three-year period," says Chakravarty.

Also, take into account the periodic travel to metro areas and other cities for networking, funding, and client meetings.

Property prices & rentals

Unless you have a family house or are moving in with your parents, a crucial decision is whether to buy or rent immediately after shifting to a smaller city. Many are attracted to the lower property costs and home loan EMIs (equated monthly instalments), which can easily translate to a bigger house.

"I have bought a 220 sq. yard plot of land and will construct a 4 BHK house later, which will cost me around ₹2.5 crore overall. For the same price, you would never be able to buy and build a *kothi* (independent house) in the National Capital Region (NCR) of Delhi," says Garg, who is currently living on rent in Chandigarh.

"In metros, the average cost of a 2-BHK (bedroom, hall, kitchen) house is around ₹1.25-1.5 crore, while a 3 BHK can cost approximately ₹2.25-2.5 crore. In tier 2/3 cities, a 2 BHK typically ranges from ₹80 lakh-1 crore, while a 3 BHK may cost around ₹1.3-1.5 crore," says Ritesh Mehta, Head—North, West & East, Residential Advisory Services, India, JLL.

The rents also vary sharply. "You pay anywhere between ₹40,000 and ₹70,000 per month for a decent 2-BHK house in Mumbai or Delhi. You will find the same configuration in Indore, Coimbatore or Nagpur for ₹10,000-18,000, a saving of ₹25,00-50,000 every month," says Santhosh Kumar, Vice Chairman, ANAROCK Group.

"These days one is expected to have a house before one gets married, but given the high property prices and loan EMIs in Mumbai and Navi Mumbai, it's impossible to afford one for 80% of the employees. This may not be true for those in the IT sector, but they too are facing uncertainty now," says Anuj Kesarwani, Founder, Zenith Finserve, a financial planning firm. Kesarwani shifted to his family house in hometown Prayagraj (formerly Allahabad) from Navi Mumbai this year.

However, it may not always be prudent to buy property right away. "Ideally, one should begin by renting. Buying a property requires a deeper understanding and familiarity with the location, infrastructure, and long-term liveability. It is advisable to spend at least 2-3 years in the city before making a purchase decision, irrespective of the prevailing market conditions," says Mehta.

“That said, in tier 2 cities such as Indore or Jaipur, property prices are low enough for the EMIs to actually be on a par with monthly rent, which makes buying a real wealth-building decision if you are sure about staying for the long term,” says Kumar. That’s another thing you will need to watch out for—whether you are sure of settling in the small town forever.

Remember, that in case you decide to move back to a metro, it may be slightly difficult to sell the property. “Liquidity can be one of the biggest challenges in tier 2/3 markets. Property sales may take longer due to the relatively lower demand and excess supply in certain locations. Additionally, promised infrastructure and social development may face delays or may not materialise as expected, which can impact resale prospects and appreciation,” says Mehta.

Cost of living, quality of life

There is also a significant difference in the cost of living between metros and tier 2 cities (see table). According to Costoflivingindia.com, a family with kids will spend approximately ₹1.2 lakh a month in Delhi, while you will need to shell out around ₹77,000 in Jaipur.

While these figures are tempting enough to relocate to a tier 2 city, remember that your income is also likely to come down, cutting down your actual savings. If, however, you are able to maintain the same income level, it could result in high savings. “The relocation should typically be a positive move since rentals, cost of living, school and doctors’ fees would be lower. If the salary remains the same, one should take care to invest the potential savings to enhance one’s lifestyle or redirect to retirement funding,” says Suresh Sadagopan, Founder, Ladder7 Financial Advisories.

However, one is also likely to make a mistake regarding the overall spending. “A general assumption is made on the topline costs such as food, stay and other basic amenities. The gaps pertaining to infrastructure, utilities, and other essential services should also be assessed,” says Dinesh Rohira, Founder & CEO, 5nance.com.

This is what Jain discovered when he moved to Indore. “I realised that my expenses had come down barely 10-20% because of the lifestyle, while my income had been slashed considerably (due to the startup),” he says.

“It’s important to consider the quality of life and lifestyle one wants to have, as well as the cost differential associated with living in a metro and tier 2 city,” says financial planner Kesarwani. “For instance, if you want to spend more time with your family and friends in your home town, it’s worth making the move,” he adds.

Quality of life was a deciding factor for Garg too. “While cost was a factor, more important was the better quality of air and water, lower commute time and traffic jams, and having my fam-



Akashdeep Garg & Rohita Rani, 40 & 39

Financial adviser & data engineer

Relocation
Delhi NCR to Chandigarh in 2022

Benefits

- Lower rentals, cost of construction.
- Lesser traffic, pollution, fuel cost.

Drawbacks

- Fewer job opportunities, especially in IT sector.

Fall in income
No change

Fall in expenses
25-30%

“I have no regrets about shifting because it’s better than a metro in every way.”

ily closer in Punjab,” says Garg, who takes 15 minutes to travel to work, compared to an hour he took in the NCR.

On the flip side, not everyone may be able to adjust to a small-city life after the comforts and conveniences of a metro city. Varun Naidu, 59, realised this when he shifted from Mumbai to Goa in 2007, wanting to escape the toxic corporate rat race. “Though the quality of life improved significantly—no pollution, lesser traffic and more time with the family—it took me a long time to adjust to the city’s culture, mindset, and frequent disruption of power and water supply.

The difference in quality of life is reflected in the quality of life index by Numbeo, which takes into account factors such as cost of living, purchasing power, healthcare, traffic commute time, pollution, safe-

ty, and climate. So while Delhi has a quality of life index value of 88.78, Jaipur is higher at 135.27; Mumbai is at 87.05, while Indore records 125.69.

Healthcare, education & social infrastructure

“If one is considering relocation to a tier 2/3 city, the economic ecosystem, along with physical and social infrastructure, becomes a critical factor in decision-making. Physical infrastructure, such as airport and road connectivity, public transport systems and proximity to employment hubs, influences mobility and day-to-day convenience. Equally important is the quality of social infrastructure, including healthcare facilities, educational institutions, hospitality, retail, and reliable civic utilities,” says Sood.

Sheel Jaitley & Abhishek Kumar

42 & 46

Entrepreneur & Sebi-RIA

Relocation
Bengaluru to Manipal in 2024

Benefits

- Fewer health issues.
- Cleaner, greener, safer & no traffic.

Drawbacks

- Networking opportunities limited.
- Fewer education options.

Fall in income
60-70%

Fall in expenses
60-70%



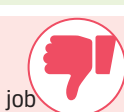
“In a metro, one spends a lot in maintaining and keeping up with societal expectations.”



RELOCATION: PROS & CONS

What’s likely to work for you...

- Property cost and loan EMIs will be lower.
- Rents will also be lower than in metros.
- Cost of living will drop.
- More time to spend with family, pursue passions.
- Commute time, fuel cost will reduce due to lesser traffic.
- Air and water pollution will be low, resulting in better health.
- Lifestyle expenses may drop.



What may not work...

- Income may fall in case of a job or if launching a new venture.
- Job opportunities may be fewer, career growth could be slower. Professional networking is likely to take a hit.
- Medical infrastructure and facilities may not be as evolved.
- Recreation, entertainment options may be fewer.
- Higher education options may be fewer.
- Real estate liquidity may be lesser than in a metro.
- Builder projects may be fewer.
- Air/rail connectivity may not be at par with metros.



“The presence of multi-speciality hospitals and specialists is a make-or-break factor, particularly for families with elderly members. For households with children, the quality of CBSE and ICSE schools and the presence of reputed colleges is non-negotiable,” agrees Kumar.

Though the cost difference for schooling and healthcare is significant, the quality may not always be at par with that in metros. “I’m spending ₹50,000 a year for my son’s education, compared to ₹5 lakh in Bengaluru, but the options and awareness level are lower in Manipal,” says Jaitley.

“The cost of higher education, in case they have to go to metros and, hence, the additional cost of running two households, should also be considered,” says Rohira.

It’s also important to pick a city with adequate healthcare facilities. For those with medical conditions, moving to smaller towns might be a problem if medical expertise isn’t available. But there’s been progress. “Though the healthcare options in Prayagraj are not as good as in metros, many big hospital chains are moving to tier 2 cities, and we are within 2-3 hours of good facilities in Lucknow,” says Kesarwani.

It’s not just about affordability but what a city can offer once you’re there. So consider all factors, financial and otherwise, before relocating from a metro to a tier 2 city.

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Benami traps

Lens on 'convenient' family investments

As the apex court enforces the 2016 framework retrospectively, informal asset arrangements now risk confiscation.



MAYANK MOHANKA
FOUNDER, TAXAARAM INDIA
AND PARTNER,
SM MOHANKA & ASSOCIATES

Where family arrangements are involved, they must comply with legal conditions, including joint ownership where required. Informal arrangements, especially involving unrelated persons, carry significant risk. The consequences are serious. It is no longer just about losing a legal claim. It can mean complete confiscation of the asset.

In India, property and investments often move within close family circles. A house in a spouse's name, shares held for a parent, or land purchased in a relative's name are common. Yet, the law draws a clear line between genuine arrangements and those meant to conceal real ownership. Understanding that line is now crucial.

The recent Supreme Court ruling has again brought the Prohibition of Benami Property Transactions Act into focus, especially on how far it can reach into past transactions. The takeaway for investors is simple: knowing what's allowed and what carries risk is a must.

What is a 'benami' transaction?

A benami transaction is one where an asset is held in one person's name but paid for by another, with the true ownership intentionally concealed. This is not limited to real estate. It extends to shares, mutual funds, bonds and even bank deposits. If a person buys land in a friend's name, invests in shares and mutual funds through another's identity to avoid scrutiny, or parks money in someone else's account while retaining control, such arrangements may fall within the benami framework. The person in whose name the asset stands is the 'benamidar', while the real owner remains hidden.

Genuine family arrangements valid

The law recognises that not all such arrangements are improper. Indian families often manage assets collectively, and the law accommodates this through clear exceptions.

Property purchased in the name of a spouse or child is usually permitted even if funded by oneself, provided the money comes from known and explained sources. Joint ownership is not required in such cases. However, where property is bought in the name of siblings, parents, or lineal ascendants and descendants, joint ownership becomes necessary, along with the requirement that the funds be explained. Assets held in fiduciary capacity—such as by trustees, partners or company directors on behalf of their respective trusts, firms, or companies—are excluded too. The law seeks to distinguish genuine family or fiduciary arrangements from those intended to conceal ownership.

Why 1988 Act had limited impact

India enacted its first benami law in 1988, barring such transactions and imposing a key restriction: a person entering into a benami arrangement couldn't later move the court to claim ownership. The law refused to aid such 'real' owners, but remained weak in practice. Though it provided for the acquisition of benami properties by the government, the machinery to implement this was never effectively operationalised. As a result, while the real owner could not enforce claims, the State also rarely stepped in. Many such arrangements, therefore, continued without serious consequences.

What changed in 2016

The 2016 amendment fundamentally trans-

What is 'benami' and what isn't

Situation/transaction	Prohibited (benami)	Not prohibited (excluded)	Penal consequences
Property or investment made in name of friend, employee or unrelated/distant relative person, but funded by oneself	✓		Confiscation of such benami property + imprisonment up to 7 years
Asset purchased from proceeds of earlier benami property	✓		Confiscation + imprisonment up to 7 years
Property or investment in the name of a spouse or child		✓	No penal consequence if purchase of such property/investment is from known sources; no joint holding needed
Property or investment in the name of a sibling or parent		✓	No penal consequence if purchase of such property/investment is from known sources; joint holding is needed
Assets held in fiduciary capacity by trustees, partners or directors		✓	No penal consequence if genuine fiduciary role

formed the 1988 law, with the definition of benami transactions widened to include layered and indirect arrangements. It also covered assets purchased from the proceeds of benami property. A full enforcement framework was introduced, empowering authorities to investigate, attach and adjudicate cases. Most importantly, the law now provides for the confiscation of benami properties.

The shift was clear. The law moved from a passive prohibition to an active enforcement regime. It is no longer just about denying claims. It now enables the State to seize and confiscate such assets and punish the defaulters with imprisonment for up to seven years.

SC case: A cautionary outcome

The recent Supreme Court ruling in 'Manjula v. Srinivas' illustrates this shift. In that dispute, one party claimed to be the real owner, asserting that although the property stood in another's name, the funds had come from the former. The opposing side argued that if that were so, the transaction itself was benami and therefore no claim could be enforced.

Under the earlier law, this argument might have simply defeated the ownership claim. But the apex court went further: it applied the stronger 2016 framework retrospectively and directed the confiscation of the property. The result was striking. The alleged real owner could not enforce their claim. At the same time, the benamidar also did not retain the property. In effect, neither side succeeded.

Importance for investors

The implications of this ruling go far beyond property disputes. Today's investment landscape includes demat accounts, mutual funds,

bonds and other financial instruments.

Any of these can fall within the benami framework if held in another person's name without a valid explanation. The expanded definition also means that reinvested proceeds from a benami asset can themselves be treated as benami.

Practical precautions to take

In this environment, financial discipline is critical. Investments should ideally be held in one's own name unless clearly permitted under law. The source of funds must be traceable and properly disclosed.

Where family arrangements are involved, they must comply with legal conditions, including joint ownership where required. Informal arrangements, especially involving unrelated persons, carry significant risk.

The consequences are serious. It is no longer just about losing a legal claim. It can mean complete confiscation of the asset.

Bottom line

The benami law today is no longer a quiet provision sitting in the statute book. It has real teeth. What may once have been seen as a convenient arrangement can now carry serious penal consequences, including the confiscation of the property or investment itself.

For investors, the message is clear. Transparency is not just good practice. It is essential protection. As the recent case shows, attempts to outsmart the system may leave both sides empty-handed, with the State emerging as the ultimate beneficiary.

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Electronic gold receipts

The gold receipt that no one's buying

EGRs are now available more widely with their launch on the NSE. But questions on storage and trading linger.

by Yasmin Hussain

It has been over four years since Sebi introduced its Gold Exchange Framework in January 2022, paving the way for electronic gold receipts (EGRs). BSE launched EGR trading in October 2022. In that time, gold ETFs have quietly built assets under management of ₹1.78 lakh crore—with 1.24 crore folios and net inflows of ₹3,040 crore in April 2026 alone, according to AMFI data. EGRs have no comparable figure to show. NSE launched EGR trading this month, hoping a wider reach might finally move the needle. The question is whether this nudge is enough—or whether EGRs remain a product in search of an audience.

How EGRs work

An EGR is a digital certificate backed by actual physical gold stored in a Securities and Exchange Board of India (Sebi)-regulated vault. The receipt is held in your demat account, like a share or ETF. You can buy EGRs in denominations of either 0.1 gram (i.e. 100 mg), 1 g, 10 g, 100 g and 1 kg.

"If you buy EGRs equivalent to 1 g, you become the beneficial owner of one gram of gold of minimum 999.5 purity stored in an accredited vault. You can buy and sell these receipts on the BSE and NSE during market hours," says Shweta Rajani, Head—Mutual funds, Anand Rath Wealth.

Unlike with gold ETFs, if you later want the gold itself, you can redeem the EGR and take physical delivery in the form of a bar or coin by paying applicable charges and 3% GST.

Years in the making

"It was only in May 2026 that NSE launched EGR trading on its platform, potentially giving the product greater visibility and reach," adds Rajan.

Harish Sharma, Associate Director, Sanctum Wealth, says EGRs took years to reach Indian bourses because they required building "an entirely new market framework around gold".

The first challenge was regulatory. Gold had to be treated not just as a commodity, but a financial security that could be held in one's demat account and traded on stock exchanges. This required Sebi to create new rules for vault managers, bourses and depositories such as the National Securities Depository Limited (NSDL) and Central Depository Services Limited (CDSL).

The second was operational. "Vault managers had to be registered and

What format of gold best suits you

Product	EGRs	Gold ETFs	Physical gold
Form	Held in demat account	Held in demat account	Coins, bars or jewellery
Backing	Specific gold stored in Sebi-regulated vaults	Gold held by the ETF fund	Gold in your possession
Liquidity	Still developing	High and well established	Depends on dealer demand
GST at purchase	No	No	3% GST upfront
Ongoing costs	Brokerage, demat and storage charges	Expense ratio and brokerage	Locker and insurance costs
Physical delivery	With a buffer	No	Immediate
Best suited for	Investors who don't seek immediate possession	Investors seeking simple gold exposure	Those who want to own gold directly



Denominations and contract sizes

Investors can buy EGRs in denominations ranging from 100 milligrams to 1 kilogram, with contracts available in both 99.5% and 99.9% purity variants.

Weight	EGR: 999 Purity	EGR: 995 Purity
1 kg	GLD1KG99	GLD1KG95
100 g	GOLD100G99	GOLD100G95
10 g	GOLD10G99	GOLD10G95
1 g	GOLD1G99	GOLD1G95
100 mg	GLD100MG99	GLD100MG95

Source: NSE

gest challenges even today. EGRs still have lower trading volumes and wider bid-ask spreads—difference between the price buyers are willing to pay and the price sellers are asking—which can make them trade at a slight premium compared to spot gold. As liquidity improves, such deviations are expected to narrow.

Costs and limitations

One of the major benefits of EGRs is their purchase via the exchange does not attract 3% Goods and Services Tax (GST), unlike direct purchases of physical gold. "However, investors still incur brokerage, exchange and demat charges. Vaulting and storage fees may also apply depending on how long you hold the receipts," says Rajani.

If you convert your EGRs into physical gold, you have to pay withdrawal and delivery charges along with 3% GST on the value of the gold at the time of redemption. You also incur storage charges and must rely on vault managers to safeguard the gold, reconcile physical holdings with electronic records, and process withdrawal requests. While Sebi's rules reduce these risks, the system still depends on the operational efficiency and financial soundness of vault managers.

Another practical limitation is that physical delivery is not immediate. Investors must submit a withdrawal request through their broker, after which the vault manager arranges delivery. Since exchanges and brokers do not specify a standard timeline, receiving the gold may take several days

depending on operational procedures and the location of the vault. Availability is also an issue as not all brokers offer EGR trading.

Taxation

EGRs are treated as listed securities for tax purposes. "If you sell them within 12 months, any profit is treated as a short-term capital gain and taxed at your applicable income tax slab rate. If you hold them for over 12 months, the gains qualify as long-term capital gains and are taxed at 12.5% without indexation," explains Rajesh H. Gandhi, Partner, Deloitte India. Converting EGRs into physical gold, or depositing physical gold to create EGRs, is not regarded as a transfer for capital gains tax purposes. As a result, this conversion does not trigger any capital gains tax.

Do EGRs fill a real gap?

EGRs bring regulation, transparency and standardisation to a market that has historically been fragmented and opaque. They are useful for investors keen on digital gold. Unlike many app-based digital gold products that operate outside Sebi's regulatory framework, EGRs are exchange-traded and backed by gold stored in Sebi-regulated vaults.

They also bridge a gap between gold ETFs and physical gold. Like gold ETFs, they can be bought and sold through a demat account during market hours. But unlike ETFs, they can be converted into physical bars or coins if you later want to take delivery. That said, whether they become widely adopted will depend on how quickly liquidity improves and whether investors see enough added value to justify storage charges and other costs. For those who only want exposure to gold prices, gold ETFs may still remain the simpler and more cost-effective option.

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MF-PMS

Does the advisory layer justify the added costs?

PMS-style mutual fund advisory can fetch you a curated selection of funds with allocation and execution embedded. This convenience faces a test of capabilities and the burden of costs.

by Sanket Dhanorkar

For the well-heeled investor, there is never a dearth of options. If you have a meaty portfolio, an asset manager or wealth advisory platform will offer 'tailored' solutions. Those seeking exclusivity often flirted with equity portfolio management services (PMS). However, the PMS space was not catering to individuals sitting on a hefty mutual fund (MF) portfolio—most were flying solo and rudderless.

Enter PMS for MFs, where fund selection, advice and execution come embedded. Wealth-tech platforms and private wealth firms are increasingly pitching "curated MF portfolios" with active allocation, tactical shifts and personalised advice. Are MFs in a PMS wrapper solving a genuine gap? Can they deliver enough bang for the extra buck?

A marriage of convenience

In essence, an MF-PMS creates personalised fund portfolios for affluent clients. It is aimed at combining the simplicity and tax-efficiency of MFs within a professional advisory structure. The sales pitch says that with over 2,500 MF schemes in India, investors face a problem of plenty. MF-PMS providers claim they use institutional-grade research to pick the best funds.

Apart from having to choose funds, behavioural discipline remains a handicap. Investors often pursue 'alpha'—or outperformance—in MFs, but experience a return drag over time, fetching returns lower than those of their chosen funds. This is a behavioural gap—investors panic, make emotional switches or chase hot performers, diluting returns.

The MF-PMS aims to improve long-term outcomes through disciplined allocation and risk management rather than mere fund selection. This is the

real alpha that they seek to deliver. To solve this problem, they charge a fee.

Sandeep Jethwani, Co-founder of wealth management firm Dezerv, observes that 53% of MF investors' portfolios underperform their benchmarks, and only 1% beat them by more than 1%. "Good funds exist. Selecting them, maintaining the right asset allocation, customising it to specific goals and liabilities, monitoring holdings scattered across platforms, and resisting behavioural traps like chasing past performance or novelty bias is hard work. Most investors do not have the time, the data or the temperament to do this consistently over a decade or more. That is what the PMS fee pays for."

Not everyone is convinced that PMS in MF offers any distinct value proposition compared to what a registered investment advisor (RIA) already does. Dharendra Kumar, CEO of investment research company Value Research, says, "Selection and allocation are solvable by any competent RIA on a flat fee. The PMS wrapper is chosen because it permits performance fees, not because the investor needs it."

Others argue that while both appear similar on the surface, the depth of engagement can differ meaningfully. This is because an RIA typically cannot exercise discretionary control over client assets the way a PMS can. While RIAs can advise clients what to do, PMS structures can actually manage and execute within agreed mandates.

According to Vidya Bala, Head—Research at portfolio management firm PrimeInvestor.in, "For a MF-based PMS, the management fee covers active portfolio construction across multiple funds and asset classes, tactical rebalancing based on market conditions, staggered deployment based on valuations, and 100% in-house research-driven decision-making—none of which an investor can replicate passively or a typical RIA can deliver in the same structured manner."

She says RIAs, by their very structure, advise—but don't actively manage. Execution remains with the investor and responding actively to changing market and category conditions is cumbersome within the RIA framework, Bala adds.

Srikanth Bhagavat, Managing Director and Principal Advisor at Hexagon Capital Advisors, concurs, "As an RIA, it is difficult to get all clients to agree on suggested actions in a time-bound manner to enable timely execution of advice. This is a challenge when there are hundreds of portfolios to administer the advice to."

Seeing double?

Critics suggest the 'double-dip' fee structure of MF-PMS makes the product unfavourable. Investors pay the PMS management fee in addition to the expense ratios of the underlying MFs. "A typical MF-PMS charges 0.6–1% fixed, or a 20% profit share, and that sits on top of the underlying scheme's expense ratio (0.5–1% in direct plans). The all-in cost ranges from 1.1–2% for the same job," explains Kumar.

A MF manager and a PMS manager are not doing the same job, and the different fees are not paying for the same work, Jethwani insists. "The MF's expense ratio pays for what happens inside the fund: research, security selection, and execution within a defined mandate. The PMS fee covers customised portfolio management, asset allocation as per financial goals, selection of right funds, execution of trades, and the behavioural layer that keeps the portfolio on plan through cycles."

Bala says the "dual fee" framing is misleading, arguing that every managed investment structure involves a service fee of some kind. A distributor earns a commission on top of the regular plan's expense ratio. An RIA charges an advisory fee in addition to direct plan expense ratios. Similarly, a PMS charges a management fee. "There is no fee-free professional management—the question is only about what you get in return," she remarks.

Profit sharing vs flat fee

The viability of MF-PMS varies based on how it charges the management fee. Some charge a fixed fee while others adopt a profit-sharing model. Under the flat fee structure, investors pay a fixed percentage of assets under advice, usually up to 1%. In profit-sharing, the PMS charges a certain percentage on gains and follows the high-watermark principle.

In other words, a PMS manager earns a performance fee only on incremental gains at every interval. This ensures that investors don't pay fees twice on the same gains or to recover losses.

So, a portfolio that initially grows from ₹50 lakh to ₹55 lakh can be charged a fee on the incremental gain. However, if its value falls to ₹52 lakh the next year, and ₹54 lakh the year after that, fee can't be charged for both years. Some include a hurdle rate—a minimum gain before a manager can share the profits.

PMS providers often tout this profit-sharing model as more investor-aligned. Kumar suggests this alignment does not hold up to scrutiny. "The performance-fee structure is asymmetric. These strategies pay the manager handsomely when markets rise. The same hurt only the client when markets fall. That is heads I win, tails you lose, dressed up as alignment."

Some new-age MF-PMS offerings have no hurdle rate at all, which means the



manager earns a performance fee simply for delivering what an index fund gives the investor for free. A flat fee, on the other hand, aligns the adviser with the investor's lifetime relationship, not with this quarter's trade. "Once you strip the marketing, performance fee is a feature for the manager; flat fee is a feature for the investor," Kumar explains.

Rajani Tandale, Senior Vice President—Mutual Fund at 1 Finance, points out, "Independent analysis shows performance-fee structures can cost investors 2–3 times a flat-fee arrangement in strong market years. Profit-sharing has merit only where the manager has a verified, benchmark-relative alpha edge across full market cycles."

Many MF-PMS providers agree that the flat fee is the superior model. Dezerv offers both structures, but Jethwani recommends the flat fee model for its predictability. "The cost and the manager's incentive remain consistent across cycles, unlike the profit share model where the fees can be lumpy during market rallies and absent during flat or bear markets."

PrimeInvestor only charges a flat fee. Bala explains, "Profit sharing can often create perverse incentives: the manager is tempted to take outsized risks or churn the portfolio to generate short-term gains that trigger taxes and churn costs. It also penalises investors in good years by taking a pound of what belongs to them."

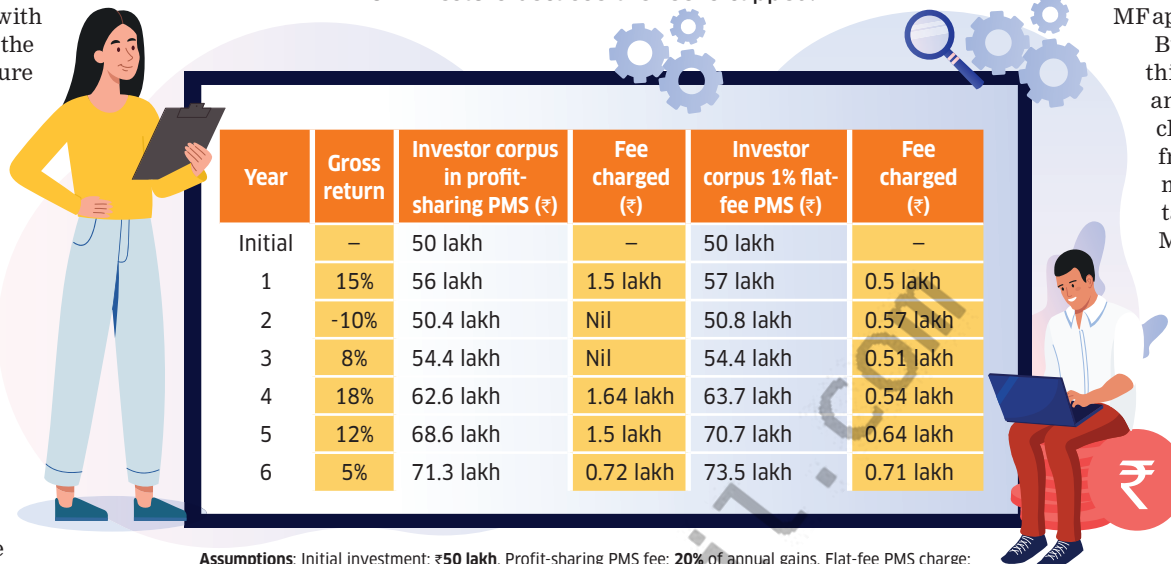
She also maintains that the flat-fee structure does not always favour the RIA model. "As portfolios grow, the fee differential at a flat-fee PMS narrows further in the investor's favour. The assumption that RIAs are automatically cheaper does not hold at the HNI (high-net-worth investor) scale," according to Bala.

Active vs passive

The viability of MF-PMS is further complicated by the choice of underlying funds—active or passive. It makes the cost argument sharper, says Kumar, adding, "If the underlying is active, the investor is paying for active management twice, once to the asset management company (AMC)

Profit-sharing PMS vs flat-fee PMS

During strong bull markets, a flat-fee structure may leave more upside for investors because the fee is capped.



Assumptions: Initial investment: ₹50 lakh. Profit-sharing PMS fee: 20% of annual gains. Flat-fee PMS charge: 1% of opening assets under management annually. Returns before fees are identical for both PMS structures.

and once to the wrapper, with no evidence that two layers of judgment beat one. If the underlying is passive, the wrapper is charging an active fee for asset allocation."

When the PMS deploys into low-cost index funds and exchange-traded funds (ETFs), the combined cost—advisory fee plus fund expense—stays in the 0.6–1.2% range, which is competitive. But stack that same advisory fee on top of actively managed funds that already charge 1.5–2.5%, and the total annual drag climbs to 2.5–4%, suggests Tandale. At that level, the underlying funds don't just need to beat the market, but beat it by enough to justify each basis point of that combined cost. That is a steep bar to clear.

As Tandale puts it, "Stack the same advisory fee on actively managed funds, and the combined drag demands consistent, verifiable alpha—a high bar given that a significant majority of active funds have historically underperformed their benchmarks."

Bala counters that even if the embedded expense ratio is higher in active funds-based PMS, the combination of superior fund selection, timely category rotation, and disciplined position-sizing can more than

offset the management fee. Jethwani maintains the structural case for MF-PMS does not change whether the underlying is active or passive, because the work above the fund has to be done regardless of how the underlying is constructed.

Churn, baby, churn

Critics argue this is where the fee math can really unravel for an MF-PMS. In regular MFs, a fund manager can rebalance the portfolio within the scheme without triggering a tax event for the investor. Tax is paid only when the investor redeems. That deferral compounds.

"A PMS does not enjoy that," insists Kumar, adding, "Every trade the manager places is in the investor's own demat account. Every realised gain is the investor's taxable event in the year it occurs." He reckons that a high-churn PMS has to clear a meaningful tax drag before it can claim alpha against a buy-and-hold mutual fund portfolio.

"The erosion scales with turnover," stresses Tandale. "Depending on churn frequency, a PMS-on-MF strat-

egy needs to generate in excess of 2-3 percentage points of additional gross returns annually just to match the post-tax outcome of a buy-and-hold MF approach."

But service providers counter this argument. Jethwani says any sale of MF, whether by the clients themselves with advice from an RIA or in a PMS by its manager, receives the same tax treatment. Even when the MF-PMS must churn, it does so modestly. "At Dezerv, we don't churn for the sake of churning unless we believe there is a really good opportunity of investing in another fund and the expected upside is significantly higher than tax paid," he explains.

Bala insists that it is incorrect to conflate every PMS with high churn, which is a legitimate concern for the traditional equity-based PMS. "Rebalancing within an MF portfolio is strategic and measured, not driven by stock-level calls. The tax treatment at redemption of each MF unit applies, but it is no different from what an fund investor would suffer as tax."

Execution unproven

MF-PMS makes a fervent pitch to solve a real gap in MF investing. Wealth managers position it as a vital tool for busy HNIs who have the capital but lack the time or emotional discipline to manage a complex MF portfolio themselves.

However, scepticism remains for this offering as it is yet to prove its credentials. Kumar emphasises that MF-PMS is best understood as the industry's response to the July 2024 hike in short-term capital gains tax on equity, which made stock-level PMS churn uneconomical. "The wrapper is a regulatory adaptation by the provider, not a product improvement for investors. The investor's problem, which was always cost and disclosure, has not been solved."

Bala counters that outcomes will eventually prove the merit in MF-PMS. "Scepticism toward any new offering is natural, and doubly so when incumbents perceive it as a threat to their model. Distributors felt the same way when direct plans arrived. RIAs faced resistance when fee-only advisory was still a novel concept. In each case, the market eventually recognised the merit. MF-based PMS is at that same nascent stage."

Ultimately, quality of advice will determine whether PMS-style advisory around MFs deserves its own place as a specialised, fee-based professional service.

How MF-PMS offerings have fared

PMS manager	Name of strategy	AUM (₹ cr)	Category	1-year return (%)		3-year return (%)	
				Strategy	Benchmark	Strategy	Benchmark
Dezerv Investments	Equity Revival Strategy	6,700	Multi cap & flexi cap	3.58	3.64	16.95	14.90
Dezerv Investments	Alpha Focus Strategy	706	Small & mid cap	10.91	3.64	NA	14.90
NJ Asset Management	Balanced Advantage Portfolio	198	Hybrid	3.94	0.63	11.42	8.80
Ionic Asset Management	Ionic Allocate Portfolio - Aggressive	123	Multi-asset	21.27	7.33	NA	12.35
Kotak Mahindra Asset Management Company	Kotak Pioneer Model Strategy Aggressive	63	Multi-asset	15.54	7.33	17.09	12.35
Ionic Asset Management	Ionic Allocate Portfolio-Equity	54	Multi cap & flexi cap	10.96	-0.28	NA	11.18
Ionic Asset Management	Ionic Allocate Portfolio - Moderate	49	Multi-asset	28.91	0.63	NA	8.80
Right Horizons	All Seasons	41	Multi-asset	12.39	6.60	15.79	12.10

Source: PMS Bazaar, Securities and Exchange Board of India. Benchmark return pertains to index chosen by the PMS strategy. The above list is not exhaustive. Returns as on 30 April 2026; returns over a 1-year period are annualised; returns are calculated using the time weighted rate of return (TWRR) method and as provided by the respective AMCs.

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New labour codes, income tax rules

Beyond the hike: appraisal recheck

From higher EPF and gratuity outgo to new tax exemptions, this appraisal season is forcing employees to recalculate their real salary gains.

by Preeti Kulkarni

For many salaried employees, the appraisal season was not a regular affair this year. Some organisations rolled out increments effective 1 April and aligned the salary structures with the new labour codes. Some also decided to incorporate tax-exempt allowances such as meal coupons, children's education and hostel expenses, whose limits were hiked under the new Income Tax rules, among others, to optimise employees' tax outgo.

Preparing for the changes

To be sure, many organisations are yet to implement the norms, even though they are actively reviewing and testing structures. "While the April-May appraisal cycle has prompted many companies to review compensation structures, a broad-based labour code-compliant rollout across India Inc. is still not evident," says Shailesh Khanna, Business Lead, ManpowerGroup India. Larger and more structured employers are using this cycle to assess impact, test revised salary breakups and prepare payroll systems. "Many others remain cautious, preferring to align changes with clearer implementation timelines, state-level readiness and market practice," he says.

Now that the labour ministry has also notified the final central labour code rules, the process is likely to gain momentum. "While several organisations have evaluated their structure with the wage definition under the codes and realigned the same as part of the annual appraisal cycle, others are still in the process. However, given that the final central rules have been notified in May, there is a growing sense of urgency," says Radhika Viswanathan, Executive Director, Deloitte India.

Central rules are applicable to establishments in specific sectors. "For example, railways, air transport,



New tax regime retains the edge over old despite higher exemptions

Despite the recently-enhanced children's education and hostel allowances under the new I-T rules, new tax regime scores unless you claim HRA under the old regime.

	Old tax regime		New tax regime	
	Without HRA	With HRA	With meal coupons	Without meal coupons
Gross salary	60,00,000	60,00,000	60,00,000	60,00,000
Less: Meal coupon exemption	1,05,600	1,05,600	1,05,600	-
Less: Children's education allowance	72,000	72,000	-	-
Less: Hostel Allowance	2,16,000	2,16,000	-	-
Less: Tax-saver deductions	1,50,000	1,50,000		
Less: Interest paid on housing loan/HRA	2,00,000	15,00,000		
Standard deduction	50,000	50,000	75,000	75,000
Taxable salary	52,06,400	39,06,400	58,19,400	59,25,000
Tax	13,74,420	9,84,420	13,25,820	13,57,500
Surcharge	1,37,442	-	1,32,582	1,35,750
Cess	60,474	39,377	58,336	59,730
Total tax payable	15,72,336	10,23,797	15,16,738	15,52,980

Notes and assumptions: 1. Children's education allowance and hostel allowance are allowed as exemptions only under the old tax regime, as per the new I-T Act rules. 2. Meal coupons @ ₹200 per meal (44 a month) are allowed under both the regimes. 3. Old tax regime calculations exclude HRA when home loan interest deduction is claimed and vice-versa. 4. Actual HRA claimed is fully tax-exempt; 5. Employers' contribution to NPS not taken into account 6. All amounts in rupees

Source: ClearTax

telecommunication, banking, oil fields, ports, etc. In other instances, the state government is the appropriate authority, and hence the state rules need to be operationalised for on-ground implementation," she adds. The process is likely to be staggered and depend on the organisations' policies.

"Some organisations have rolled out increments along with labour codes' compliant compensation structure in April. Many others are likely to announce hikes only in May and June," says Balasubramanian A., Senior Vice-President, Teamlease Services.

By combining appraisals with labour code-linked implementation, organisations are mitigating the impact of reduced take-home pay due to the increased statutory social security obligations. "There is still some degree of fluidity, there is no 100% certainty yet, though the broad direction is becoming clearer," he says.

According to him, the adoption is currently more visible among large enterprises and compliance-intensive sectors, while smaller firms are adopting a more wait-and-watch approach due to concerns around cost

impact and take-home pay adjustments.

Labour code impact decoded

Salaried individuals who have received their appraisal letters now have the onerous task of decoding their revised compensation structures and evaluating the newly-introduced tax exemptions, effective 1 April.

The immediate takeaway for employees is that a salary hike this appraisal season may not necessarily translate into a proportionate increase in take-home pay. This is because the revised wage definition under the labour codes requires at least 50% of total remuneration to be treated as wages for the calculation of social security obligations, including gratuity and Employees' State Insurance (ESI).

"For example, if someone earning a ₹100 CTC (cost to company) receives an 8% increment, they may expect take-home pay to rise by ₹8. However, if their employees' provident fund (EPF) wages (basic salary component, primarily) were below ₹50 to begin with, or they come under the ambit of ESI (employee state insurance) for the first time, then, it is possible that out of the ₹8 increment, a part of it, say ₹3, could go towards meeting the additional statutory obligations, leaving an actual increase in take-home salary of only around ₹5," says Subramanian. Employees whose basic salaries are below ₹15,000 will likely see a dip in their take-home salaries as gratuity and EPF components rise. Gratuity is now linked to 50% of the total remuneration, unlike earlier when it was pegged to the basic pay, which was typically 30-40% of the CTC. It is bound to go up across salary levels and organisations.

Employees also need to keep an eye on the impact on the EPF contribution. "The basic salary is predominantly retained at the same levels in the realigned structure and

hence there is no impact on the EPF contribution for those with the monthly basic salary of over ₹15,000," says Vishwanathan.

Balasubramian of Teamlease says a broad pattern is emerging, with companies gradually moving towards a higher basic pay component as a proportion of total compensation, in line with the labour code-linked wage definitions. "This shift is not limited to employees earning below the ₹15,000 EPF threshold; in many organised-sector roles, basic pay revisions are being applied more uniformly across grades to maintain internal parity and simplify payroll structures," he says. As a result, EPF contributions have increased in several cases, particularly for employees where EPF is calculated on actual basic wages rather than being capped. "While this strengthens long-term retirement savings and social security coverage, it can also reduce immediate take-home pay, which is why some firms are adopting phased adjustments rather than abrupt restructuring," he adds.

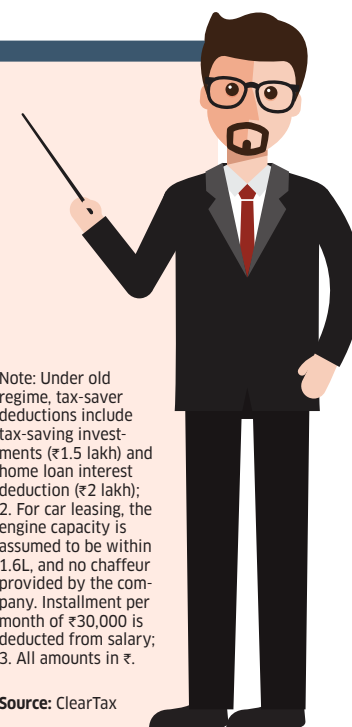
Essentially, for those with basic pay over ₹15,000, the impact on in-hand pay will, therefore, depend on the employers' approach. "(For such employees), the salary-structure changes have usually had limited direct impact on monthly take-home, unless the company also changed its EPF contribution policy. In many companies, EPF for higher-salaried employees was already being capped rather than calculated on the full basic," says Khanna. For such employees, EPF will not automatically rise even if basic pay moves up as part of salary restructuring. What will change instead is the mix of components, higher basic, lower special/flexible allowances and higher gratuity

How car lease impacts your tax outgo

Particulars	Old tax regime	New regime with meal coupons and car lease	New regime without meal coupons and car lease
Gross salary	1,20,00,000	1,20,00,000	1,20,00,000
Less: Meal coupon exemption	1,05,600	1,05,600	
Less: Children's education allowance	72,000		
Less: Hostel allowance	2,16,000		
Less: Tax-saver deductions	3,50,000		
Less: Car leasing installments*	3,60,000	3,60,000	
Add: Car perquisite value	60,000	60,000	
Standard deduction	50,000	75,000	75,000
Taxable salary	1,09,06,400	1,15,19,400	1,19,25,000
Tax payable	30,84,420	30,35,820	31,57,500
Surcharge	4,62,663	4,55,373	4,73,625
Cess	1,41,883	1,39,648	1,45,245
Total tax payable	36,88,966	36,30,841	37,76,370

Note: Under old regime, tax-saver deductions include tax-saving investments (₹1.5 lakh) and home loan interest deduction (₹2 lakh); 2. For car leasing, the engine capacity is assumed to be within 1.6L, and no chauffeur provided by the company. Installment per month of ₹30,000 is deducted from salary; 3. All amounts in ₹.

Source: ClearTax



provisioning.

"EPF contribution at the rate of 12% is not mandatory if the basic salary is well over the EPF wage ceiling of ₹15,000 per month. In many cases, provident fund contributions may still remain capped at ₹1,800, depending on the employee's choice and employers' policies. In such cases, take-home will not be impacted by increased EPF contributions," explains Subramanian.

Old regime back into focus

This appraisal season has also seen greater use of flexible benefit components after the

new income tax rules linked to the Income Tax Act, 2025 came into effect on 1 April. "For instance, companies are increasingly using meal benefits, education-related allowances, hostel allowances, wellness benefits and reimbursement-based components to maintain tax efficiency and employee retention while remaining within the new wage framework," says Keyur D. Gandhi, Managing Partner at Gandhi Law Associates.

The rules have raised the tax-exemption limits on allowances such as children's education and hostel expenses (for up to two children) under the old tax regime. Reflecting rising living and education costs, the monthly tax-exempt allowance for children's education has been increased from ₹100 to ₹3,000 per child, while the hostel allowance has been raised from ₹300 to ₹9,000 per child. In another key change, salaried individuals in Bengaluru, Pune, Hyderabad and Ahmedabad will now be eligible for House Rent Allowance (HRA) exemption of up to 50% of their basic salary, up from 40%. This brings these cities at par with Delhi, Mumbai, Chennai and Kolkata. Moreover, meal and refreshment coupon exemption has gone up from ₹50 to ₹200 per meal, and this is available under both the regimes from this year. Since Budget 2025, the new income tax regime had emerged as a clear winner with lower tax rates, friendlier tax slabs, and higher exemption and rebate limits. The higher exemption limits on these allowances will now necessitate a reworking of the math and re-evaluation of the tax outgo under the old and new tax regimes.

To be sure, not all organisations will offer these benefits as the exercise will entail increase in cumbersome paperwork for employers as well as employees. Until the new rules were rolled out, only 10-15% of corporates in India offered benefits such as children's education and hostel allowances. If your employer has decided to incorporate such benefits into your pay packages, however, it's decision-making time for you.

ClearTax calculations show that for high-income earners, for instance, individuals with gross salaries over ₹60 lakh, the new

regime is likely to have an edge. Even if the taxpayer were to exhaust the Section 80C tax-saver investments of ₹1.5 lakh (Schedule XV under the new I-T Act), home loan interest (₹2 lakh) as well as children's education and hostel expense allowances, her tax outgo will be higher by nearly ₹19,000 under the old tax regime. What tilts the scales is essentially house rent allowance (HRA), as the tax payable under the old regime goes down by over ₹4.93 lakh if she were to pay rent of ₹15 lakh per annum and claim the exemption.

Under the new tax regime, utilise the meal coupons if your employer offers the same. This can cut your outgo by close to ₹36,000 (when compared to a scenario where meal benefits are not offered).

Besides these allowances, you also need to take a call on opting for other tax optimisation measures like fuel reimbursement and car lease facilities offered by employers. However, these reimbursement-based benefits are allowed under both the tax regimes. Take note of the new motor car perquisite rules before you put a tax planning strategy in place at the beginning of the financial year. ClearTax calculations show that compared to not availing of such benefits under the new regime, a taxpayer earning ₹1.2 crore per annum will save close to ₹1.45 lakh, if she does.

Finally, the decision will also hinge on your willingness to deal with the voluminous paperwork involved in claiming multiple deductions and exemptions. Over the past few years, the income tax department has increased scrutiny of such claims and has been issuing notices seeking documentary proof for the tax benefits availed. If you do choose to avail of the benefits, ensure that you have the necessary documentary proof in place that can be furnished should I-T queries arise.

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I-T rules 2026: Old tax regime back in focus

Advantage: employees with multiple deductions

- Employees whose companies offer generous flexible benefit components
- Salaried employees living in rented accommodation and claiming HRA
- Parents with two children, both of whom live in hostels
- Higher HRA exemption limit (50%) for employees in Bengaluru, Hyderabad, Pune and Ahmedabad
- Individuals with large deductions (home loan interest + insurance + NPS)

Limited benefit

- High earners without HRA
- Employees with rigid salary structures across the organisation
- Taxpayers who want to avoid extensive paperwork, risk of I-T queries
- Professionals working in companies that offer simplified CTC structures

Take note

- Higher exemption limits will not necessarily translate into significant savings under the old regime
- For high earners, HRA will remain the chief source of meaningful tax savings
- Many taxpayers will continue to benefit from the new regime's simplicity, lower rates

Deciding factor

- Choose old regime if:** You claim HRA + multiple deductions
- Choose new regime if:** You claim limited exemptions, want simplicity and minimal paperwork

Take note of higher exemption limits

Provisions	Current exemption limits	After 1 April 2026	Applicability
House rent allowance	50% of basic pay in Mumbai, Delhi, Kolkata and Chennai; 40% in other cities	Bengaluru, Hyderabad, Pune, Ahmedabad too eligible for 50% relief	Old regime
Children's education fees	₹100 per child per month*	₹3,000 per child per month*	Old regime
Hostel expenses	₹300 per child per month*	₹9,000 per child per month*	Old regime
Value of gifts from employers	₹5,000 a year	₹15,000 a year	Both regimes

Source: Deloitte India and ET Wealth research
The list of enhanced exemptions is not exhaustive. *Maximum up to two children.

Smart beta funds

Passive investing has a noise problem

There are too many passive funds, but not enough clarity. You need just a few. So which ones are they?



DEV ASHISH
FOUNDER, STABLEINVESTOR

While there is a growing tribe of passionate passive-only believers (a perfectly legitimate approach), it's best to take a middle path and build a portfolio that has allocation to both passive and active components.

The Indian passive funds space has a problem now: hyper activity. The explosion in the number of passive fund options launched by asset management companies (AMCs) has made the erstwhile quiet corner of passive investing, into something of a noisy park. And while having options is a good thing, this extreme activeness in the passive space is confusing small investors.

Some people may want to put the blame on AMCs for launching too many options. But that is not what the focus is today. Let's try to make sense of the passive clutter and see if we can identify a few options that are sufficient for most investors.

Large-cap index funds Best suited for passive

After the Securities and Exchange Board of India tightened the definition for large-cap funds (plus all other categories) and introduced total return index (TRI) benchmarks a few years ago, most active largecap funds have been finding it increasingly difficult to consistently outperform large-cap indices on a rolling-return basis.

Therefore, for most investors' large-cap requirements, a plain-vanilla Nifty 50 index fund is sufficient. Nifty Next50, though classified as a large-cap index, behaves wildly and has all the traits of mid-small cap in terms of risk and drawdowns. But if one is slightly more aggressive and comfortable with higher risks/volatility in exchange for potentially better returns, adding the Nifty Next50 index fund can also be considered in a small way.

Or simply, a Nifty 100 fund can give a mix of both though skewed towards Nifty 50 (as Nifty 100 has about 85% weightage of Nifty 50 and only the remaining to Next50)

Mid-caps & small-cap indexes Don't rush to go passive

Here's where things get different. Unlike the large cap space, the mid cap and small cap segment in India isn't fully efficient yet. Skilled active fund managers consistently beat their benchmarks in this space meaningfully. Hence, it's best to take the active route in mid-cap and small-cap funds.

But does that mean passive mid-cap funds are bad? Not at all. They're perfectly fine if index-level returns are acceptable to you. But given how good active fund managers have done in this space, it is suggested to remain active in this space. As for small caps, best to skip the passive small caps category.

Purists may not like what I said above, i.e. mixing passive and active funds to build a resilient, style-and market cap-diversified portfolio. But different market segments have different alpha potentials and hence,

Index examples

Large cap	Nifty 50
	Sensex
	Nifty Next50
	Nifty 100
Mid cap	Nifty Midcap 150
Large cap & mid cap	Nifty Large & Midcap 250
Small cap	Nifty Smallcap 50
	Nifty Smallcap 250
Mid cap & small cap	Nifty MidSmallcap 400
Broad market	Nifty 500
	Nifty Total Market Index
Single factor & multi factor	Nifty Alpha 50
	Nifty 50 Equal Weight
	Nifty Alpha Low Volatility 30
	Nifty100 Alpha Low Volatility 30
	Nifty 100 Low Volatility 30
	Nifty200 Momentum 30
	Nifty Midcap150 Momentum 50
	Nifty500 Value 50
	Nifty 200 Quality 30
	Nifty Midcap 150 Quality 50

they can and should be blended while building a solid portfolio. This is not to say that passive-only portfolios are bad. One can even go for one Nifty 500 index fund to get a broad diversification and be done.

Factor funds Few interesting, most avoidable

This is where passive becomes complex. Factor-based index funds are designed to beat plain-vanilla indexing by tilting portfolios toward specific attributes like quality, momentum, low volatility, or value. On paper and in theory, the back-tested data looks attractive for most. But in practice and the real world, all of them don't offer desirable investment outcomes to all types of investors.

So if you want to add a fund from this space, make sure to limit your exposure. And compared to single-factor, the multi-factor indices (which combine 2 or more factors like quality + low volatility) tend to have more stable outcomes).

For sophisticated investors who understand the nuances of factor investing, combining these smart beta funds with other pure passive or active funds can be considered. But for others, don't get into these on hunches or borrowed conviction. If in doubt, just skip.

Sectoral/thematic indexes

Most investors are better off investing in broad, diversified indexes and don't need to take sectoral or thematic bets. And these days, there are several innovative themes on offer. But innovative doesn't always mean profitable. Narrow, sector/theme specific investments suit sophisticated investors who can time both entries and exits well. Not for everyone.

Summing it up

While there is a growing tribe of passionate passive-only believers (a perfectly legitimate approach), my view is that given where India is on the economic trajectory and market maturity, it's best to take a middle path and build a portfolio with allocation in both passive and active components. A possible approach can be to first pick simple passive large-cap index funds for large-cap exposure; then add active funds for non-large caps (i.e. active mid-cap and/or small-cap funds) and style diversification (flexi-cap/multi-cap/focused/value funds/etc.) where the potential for alpha justifies extra costs.

Please send your feedback to
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Know your stocks

A low valuation isn't always a bargain

These valuation ratios help investors separate real value from value traps.

by Sameer Bhardwaj

In equity markets, the stock prices are readily visible, but it is the underlying value that truly matters. Is the stock really worth? Is it cheap or expensive? For many retail investors, distinguishing between the two is not straightforward. Absolute valuation methods such as discounted cash flow (DCF) rely on concepts like weighted average cost of capital (WACC), terminal value, and discount rates, which can make investing appear overly technical.

While DCF models are widely respected in finance, they depend heavily on assumptions about growth, profitability, and interest rates. Even small changes in these assumptions can dramatically alter valuation. This is one reason why relative valuation remains the most widely used framework in day-to-day market discussions.

Relative valuation is simpler and more intuitive. Instead of forecasting cash flows, it compares a company with similar listed peers using valuation multiples, asking a basic question: how much investors are paying for a company's performance versus its peers? At its core, it assumes similar businesses should trade at similar valuations. But relative valuation comes with a caveat: a stock is not necessarily attractive because it trades at a lower multiple, nor overvalued simply because it trades at a premium.

Consider two companies: one trades at 50 times earnings and another at 20 times. The cheaper-looking stock may seem attractive, but if the former is growing profits at 35-40% annually while the latter faces weak demand, falling margins, or balance sheet stress, the premium valuation may simply reflect stronger fundamentals and better long-term prospects.

Different sectors use different valuation metrics because business models vary. Investors therefore need to understand not just valuation multiples, but the logic behind them. Here are some commonly used relative valuation metrics:

Price to earnings (P/E) multiple: The investors' favourite

It compares a company's share price with its earnings per share (EPS), showing how much investors pay for every rupee of profit. For instance, if a stock trades at ₹500 and earns ₹25 per share, its P/E ratio is 20.

Where it works best

- Mature and stable businesses
- Fast-Moving Consumer Goods, Information Technology, consumer goods, and pharmaceuticals

What works?

- Easy to understand, widely available
- Useful for comparing similar profitable businesses
- Reflects market expectations around growth and profitability

A quick guide to valuation multiples

Multiple	Formula	Best for
P/E	Market price divided by EPS	Mature and stable businesses
Lower P/E - undervalued or weak growth prospects. High P/E - Overvalued or stronger growth expectations. Better to make comparisons within sector.		
PEG	P/E divided by estimated growth rate	Fast-growing businesses across sectors
Below 1 is often considered attractive. Higher PEG may indicate overvaluation.		
P/S	Market capitalisation divided by revenue	High-growth or loss-making businesses.
Lower the better.		
P/BV	Share price divided by book value per share	Banks and financial institutions
Better to use with return on equity. Less than 1: Undervalued. Higher P/BV coupled with high RoE may reflect quality.		
EV/Ebitda	Enterprise value divided by Ebitda	Capital intensive companies
Lower the better. Varies significantly across sectors, better to compare within sector.		

Note: P/E: price to earnings, PEG: price to earnings growth, P/S: price to sales, P/BV: price to book value, EV/Ebitda: enterprise value to earnings before interest, taxes, depreciation and amortisation.

What doesn't?

- Not useful when profits are negative or highly volatile
- Earnings can be influenced by accounting adjustments
- A low P/E doesn't always signal undervaluation and high P/E may simply reflect stronger future growth expectations

PEG ratio (price/earnings to growth): linking P/E with growth

The PEG ratio adjusts the P/E for earnings growth and shows how much investors are paying for future growth. A PEG of 1 is often seen as fair, while a much higher ratio may indicate overpaying for growth.

Where it works best

- Fast-growing businesses/sectors

What works?

- Helps assess whether high P/E valuations are justified
- Connects valuation with earnings growth expectations
- Useful in comparing growth companies.

What doesn't?

- Growth estimates can be uncertain
- Overly optimistic assumptions can distort valuations.

Price to sales (P/S) ratio: Pricing growth before profitability

High-growth companies often report losses in their early years as they spend heavily on expansion, logistics and technology. In such cases, the P/S ratio compares a company's market value with its revenues.

Where it works best

- Internet and technology companies,

E-commerce and platform businesses, and startups and early-stage growth firms

What works?

- Useful for high-growth businesses that are not yet profitable
- Revenue is generally harder to manipulate than earnings
- Helps compare companies focused on scale and market share

What doesn't?

- Revenue growth alone does not guarantee profitability
- Ignores margins and operating efficiency
- A company can grow sales rapidly while continuing to lose money

Price-to-book value (P/BV): preferred metric for banks

Unlike manufacturers or tech firms, a bank's business is its balance sheet. It borrows through deposits and lends via loans, with the difference between assets and liabilities forming its book value, or net worth. The P/BV ratio compares a bank's market price with its per-share book value. If a bank's book value per share is ₹200 and the stock trades at ₹300, the P/BV is 1.5x — investors are paying ₹1.50 for every ₹1 of the bank's net worth. A P/BV above 1 reflects confidence in the bank's ability to generate strong returns on its capital. A P/BV below 1 signals that the market doubts whether the bank's assets are actually worth what the books say. In the banking sector, P/BV is therefore always read alongside Return on Equity (RoE).

Where it works best

- Banks, Non-Banking Finance Companies

(NBFC), and other financial institutions

What works?

- Directly reflects the strength of the balance sheet
- Useful for assessing capital adequacy and financial stability
- Helps compare lenders with similar business models

What doesn't?

- Book value is backward-looking and may not capture future earnings potential
- Asset quality problems, such as rising bad loans, can make book value misleading

A low P/BV bank may look cheap on paper, but it could be masking deeper balance sheet stress. The ratio works best when read alongside asset quality data and return ratios, not in isolation.

Enterprise value-to-Ebitda (EV/Ebitda): For capital-intensive businesses

When you buy a company, you are not just paying for its shares, you are also inheriting its debts. Enterprise Value (EV) reflects the true cost of buying a company — market cap plus debt, minus cash. So, two companies with similar market caps can have very different EVs.

Ebitda — earnings before interest, taxes, depreciation, and amortisation — strips away financing decisions and accounting charges to show what the core business is actually earning from its operations. Interest depends on the amount of debt a company carries. Depreciation reflects past investments, not current cash. Removing these gives a cleaner, more comparable picture of operating performance across companies.

EV/Ebitda asks: if you bought the entire business, including its debt, how many years of operating earnings would it take to recover the cost? A 5x multiple means five years. It is useful in capital-intensive sectors where high debt can make P/E ratios misleading.

Where it works best

Cement, Telecom, Infrastructure, Manufacturing, Metals sectors.

What works?

- Helps compare companies with different debt levels
 - Neutralises accounting differences
 - Focuses on operating performance
- What doesn't?**
- Ebitda does not represent actual cash flow and can overstate profitability in capital-heavy industries

Dude, where's my money?

Expense tracking apps, AI tools, and old-fashioned Excel sheets, are changing how Indians invest—by first making them face what they spend.

by Abhinav Kaul

Most people don't know where their money goes. They have a rough sense—rent, groceries, a few subscriptions—but the true picture, with all its leakages and blind spots, stays blurry. Personal finance conversations largely revolve around products, which mutual fund to buy, which stock to pick. Financial experts and individuals are discovering that the investment journey often begins much earlier: when individuals first understand how they spend.

Expense-tracking apps, spreadsheets, Artificial Intelligence (AI)-generated analysis, and budgeting dashboards are not merely book-keeping tools. They reveal recurring patterns, unconscious leakages, and hidden habits that quietly shape long-term wealth outcomes.

A shocking realisation

Chennai resident Paranitharan S. spent 13 years in the Information Technology (IT) field before striking out on his own as a mutual fund distributor four months ago. He has been using an expense tracking app called Spendee since 2017-18, long before he made the leap to self-employment. His reason for starting was simple and deliberate: he wanted to move his monthly Systematic Investment Plan (SIP) from ₹5,000 to ₹10,000, and to do that, he first needed to know where his money was going.

"The first thing when you want to start investments is you want to know where your money is going," says



Paranitharan S., 44
Chennai, self employed
Wanted to raise the share of salary allocated to investments beyond 10%

Impact of expense tracking: Immediate 5-10% increase in investments



44-year-old Paranitharan. "I wanted a systematic way to track my spending and understand where my money was going. That's how it all started."

He uses the free version of Spendee, feeding in expenses manually, partly out of habit, partly because he did not want to give a third-party app access to his bank accounts. Every purchase goes in by the end of the day. On the last day of every month, he exports the data to Excel to understand where the money has gone.

The surprises came early. Paranitharan thought he was spending ₹5,000-6,000 on groceries, but it turned out that he was spending up to ₹12,000 regularly. Expenses on clothes were high too, much to his surprise. "I never imagined I'd be someone who spent so much on clothes," he says. Over time, though, the surprises faded. Now, the numbers broadly match his expectations. The clarity is built in.

The impact on his investment behaviour has been material. Before 2017, his investment rate hovered around 10% of income. By 2020, it had climbed to 40-50%. He does not attribute the entire jump to the app; income levels changed too, but he estimates that tracking expenses directly contributed a 5-10% increase in his savings.

That habit proved especially valuable when he decided to quit his job.

Better control of expenses

Anjana Jayalakshmi's relationship with money has long been shaped by shyness. The 27-year-old senior content consultant from Chennai describes herself as someone who grew up avoiding conversations about money, never asking questions or taking part in financial discussions. She started budg-



Anjana Jayalakshmi, 27
Chennai, senior content consultant
Tracking expenses via Excel was exhausting, and left gaps

Impact of expense tracking: 50% jump in investments

eting when she was 20, through rows and columns in Excel, spending two hours every month trying to assemble a complete picture from her own memory and bank messages. The effort was exhausting, and left gaps.

She discovered GoalSeek, a personal finance app, almost by accident, through a professional project involving the startup, and decided to try it. When she synced her bank account, the picture that emerged was different from anything her Excel sheet had shown her.

"Everything was like a treadmill journey for me. I was always on the run when it came to money, and I didn't know how to balance it all, because I spent a lot of time and effort just budgeting and writing expenses down."

The app replaced those tedious hours with a pie chart she checks every 15 days. Zomato, Swiggy, movie tickets—the app automatically pulls in her UPI transactions, categorises them, and shows her, at a glance, what the month is looking like.

On GoalSeek, she has set aside ₹20-30 lakh for a master's degree she plans to pursue in five to six years, and a separate goal for a wedding. A feature on the app calculates how much she needs to save each month to hit those targets.

"I'm less overwhelmed when it comes to money, and not shy anymore," she says. "I don't overspend, but I don't underspend too. I take a look at the pie chart, and get an understanding. I believe that one can indulge in a guilty pleasure, and it's not the end of the world."

Jayalakshmi has seen almost 50% jump in her investments since she started using the app. Two days before this interview, a friend invited her to an IPL match. She looked at her pie chart, saw the health-related expenses her parents had incurred that month, and declined. It saved her roughly ₹5,000-6,000. A small decision, made in a moment, because the data was right there.

Smarter investment journey

Tanvi Taneja, 34, vice-president, marketing, at a Pune-based fintech startup, Famli, has moved beyond dedicated apps. She tried several but found that too many transactions were misclassified or left uncategorised by automated systems. Today, she feeds her monthly bank statements into AI tools to get a fast and accurate breakdown. Her bigger revelation was not about curbing spending but about what all that visibility did to her thinking about investing. "Once I started actively tracking, I started paying more attention to the return I get on all my investments, and to how I can increase that. I saw some unclaimed money in one of my bank accounts, and one of the mutual funds I noticed was not performing well. That helped me in taking the right investment decisions." The act of watching money naturally led to the question of where it should go.

The bigger picture

Jayalakshmi, Paranitharan, and Taneja are not outliers. A survey conducted between August and September 2025 by CGAP, a US-based think tank that promotes financial inclusion, found that 85% of personal finance management (PFM) app users in India reported improvements in their ability to manage their finances because of these tools, with 31% reporting significant improvement. The study released in March 2026 covered 274 PFM users drawn from a national smartphone panel.

The findings align with what Dante De Gori, Chief Executive Officer of FPSB International, has long argued about the

psychology of spending. “Tracking and managing expenses is one of the most important foundations of successful investing,” he says.

When individuals have a clear understanding of where their money is going, they are better positioned to make financial decisions, reduce unnecessary spending, and identify opportunities to invest consistently towards their short-term and long-term goals. “From a behavioural perspective, spending awareness also helps build healthier money habits. It encourages individuals to differentiate between impulsive and purposeful spending, improving financial discipline over time,” says De Gori.

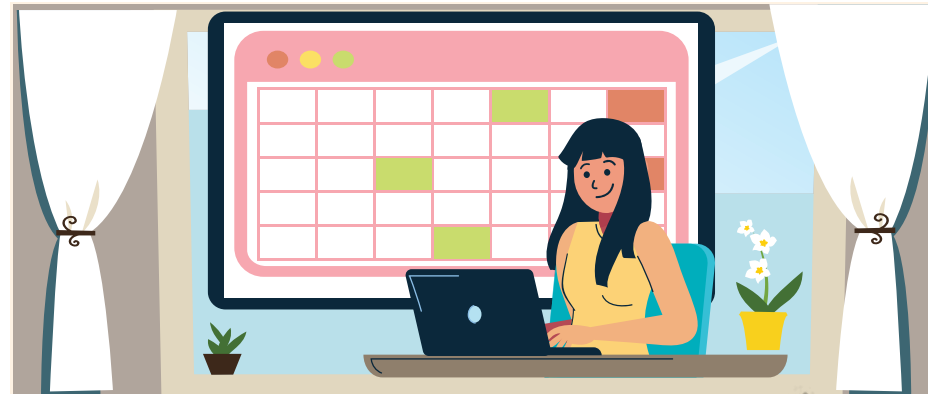
What the apps are seeing

Palak Chauhan, Founder and CEO of GoalSeek, a Sebi-registered investment adviser platform built on the account aggregator framework, tracks spending behaviour across thousands of users in India and says the trends are striking. Quick commerce tops the list of hidden spending. “The amount of money people are spending on quick commerce is mind-boggling. For some people, the frequency is two, four, even five times a day on the same app and what they’re not realising is that even ₹100, ₹500 orders quietly add up to ₹10,000-20,000 a month,” she says. Beyond quick commerce, Chauhan says the categories that have grown most visibly over the last two years are dining experiences, flights, vacations, pets and wellness, including salon and grooming. “These categories are increasing by nearly 10-15% year on year, reflecting not just inflation but a broader shift toward lifestyle and experience spending.”

She sees the UPI economy as both an enabler and a complication. “One thing we have heard from everybody is that money is just flowing with UPI. People have no idea where their money is going.”

This near-invisibility of small digital payments is what makes tracking apps so valuable, and so necessary. GoalSeek is also working on a peer benchmarking feature to show users how they compare to others of similar age, income, and city, because, as she notes, spending realities vary enormously across India.

“The moment people can actually see



How to track expenses using excel

STEP 1

Create two separate lists

Monthly fixed expenses

- Rent/EMI
- Groceries
- Utilities
- Internet/mobile bills
- Transport
- Household expenses



Annual/occasional expenses

- Insurance premiums
- School fees
- Festival shopping
- Birthdays/gifts
- Travel/trips home
- Club memberships
- Dining/shopping splurges



STEP 3

Keep annual expense money separate

- A separate bank account, or
- A liquid fund

STEP 2

Calculate your real monthly expense

- Add up all annual expenses
- Divide the total by 12
- You get the monthly burden of yearly costs



STEP 4

Track spending regularly

Update the Excel/Google Sheet frequently
Categorise spending into:

Fixed	Discretionary	Annual

STEP 5

Focus on discretionary leaks

Common blind spots include:

- Impulse shopping
- Food delivery
- Festivals
- Birthdays
- Dining out
- Small lifestyle spends



STEP 6

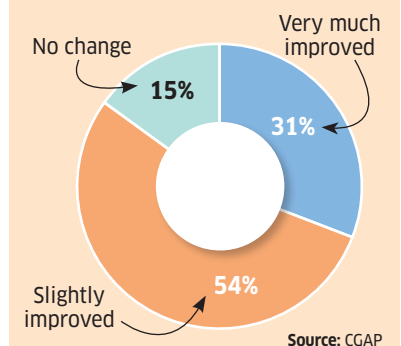
Use AI for spending insights

Upload expense sheet, instead of sharing confidential bank statements:

- Spending breakdowns
- Expense ratios
- Investment vs income analysis
- Category-wise spending patterns

How tracking expenses can help

85% of respondents in a CGAP survey reported improvements in their ability to manage their finances because of personal finance management (PFM) apps



Got slightly worse: 0%, Got much worse: 0%
CGAP survey, conducted between August and September 2025, included 274 screened PFM users.

monthly expenses as “somewhere between ₹1 lakh and ₹1.5 lakh.” That ₹50,000 variance, when tracked over a few months, often reveals real money that can be redirected. “Once we’ve done this exercise for a few months and reviewed the expense sheets, we usually find another ₹10,000–20,000 that can be channelled into an SIP, which is a significant amount,” he says.

For clients wary of sharing banking data with third-party apps, Mondal suggests a simple alternative: track expenses manually in Excel or Google sheets. One list should cover fixed monthly costs like rent and groceries, while another captures annual expenses such as insurance premiums, school fees, birthdays, and festival shopping. Add up yearly costs, divide by 12, and save that amount monthly in a separate account or liquid fund. Once spending data is recorded, AI tools can analyse this or bank statements to generate detailed spending reports, category-wise expense breakdowns, investment-to-income ratios, and insights into personal spending habits without relying entirely on fintech apps.

The first step

Before you can plan where your money goes, you have to see where it is already going. The mechanism, whether an expense tracking app, an Excel sheet, or a bank statement fed into an AI, matters far less than the act itself.

As De Gori of FPSB International puts it: “Even small adjustments in everyday expenses can create meaningful opportunities to build savings and investments through the power of consistency and compounding. Without a proper understanding of expenses, people may struggle to prepare for emergencies, achieve financial goals, or build long-term financial security.”

Knowing where the money goes is not a preliminary step to financial planning. It is the plan.

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Tanvi Taneja, 34

Marketing executive, Pune

Wanted to have a better understanding of expenses

Impact of expense tracking: Helped in taking the right investment decisions

where their money is going, they begin identifying spending leaks almost immediately. We’ve seen users become far more intentional with their money, increase their savings, and start investing more consistently simply because they finally have clarity,” says Chauhan.

On the role of AI, Chauhan is particularly optimistic. “While people may hesitate to ask personal finance questions to their friends or family, they don’t hesitate to ask AI, especially on a finance app. People are asking things like, ‘Should I buy a house right now?’, ‘Can I afford to quit my job?’, ‘Am I saving enough?’ AI responds directly and without judgment.”

The tools are improving, but they are not yet complete. Saikrishna Musunuru, Founder and CEO of Payinstacard, identifies a critical gap: “There is no prediction layer. Most of the apps currently in the market are just tracking your money that has

already been spent. There is no prediction layer; it’s not going to predict where you are likely to spend or how much you are likely to incur as an expense, and there are no controls either. So that’s the missing piece I can see.”

The adviser’s view

Upasana Mondal, a Registered Investment Adviser and founder of DreamBlueprintz, works with clients across the income spectrum and begins every financial plan with a single, often uncomfortable exercise: figuring out what the client actually spends on. “It has a bigger impact than what people assume. Most people are more bothered about where to invest, what returns funds are giving, but it is all linked to how much you are spending in a month, and that will also decide how soon you can retire,” she says. She frequently encounters a revealing discrepancy: clients who estimate their

Global markets

AI powers Japan, commodities lift Brazil in 2026 so far

Welcome to TrendMap, your visual guide to investment performance. This edition tracks 10 years of global equity returns. Currency fluctuations impact the returns on foreign investments. To capture the real value from an Indian investor's standpoint, these returns are adjusted to reflect their equivalent in Indian rupees. Key takeaway: diversification helps navigate market cycles. By Sameer Bhardwaj.



THE ECONOMIC TIMES
wealth



Rank	2017	2018	2019	2020	2021	2022	2023	2024	2025	2026*	10-year return
1	India Nifty 50 28.7%	Brazil Bovespa 4.6%	USA S&P 500 30.9%	Japan Nikkei 225 26.4%	USA S&P 500 31.2%	Brazil Bovespa 25.9%	Brazil Bovespa 40.0%	USA S&P 500 27.9%	Brazil Bovespa 57.7%	Brazil Bovespa 32.1%	USA S&P 500 17.8%
2	Hong Kong Hang Seng 25.2%	India Nifty 50 4.1%	Germany DAX 26.1%	China SSE Composite 23.0%	India Nifty 50 23.8%	Mexico MXSE IPC 7.3%	Mexico MXSE IPC 35.6%	Hong Kong Hang Seng 23.4%	Mexico MXSE IPC 55.0%	Japan Nikkei 225 27.3%	Japan Nikkei 225 14.1%
3	Germany DAX 19.9%	USA S&P 500 2.1%	China SSE Composite 24.0%	USA S&P 500 18.0%	Mexico MXSE IPC 17.9%	India Nifty 50 2.7%	USA S&P 500 25.3%	Germany DAX 15.8%	Germany DAX 46.5%	Mexico MXSE IPC 20.2%	Germany DAX 13.6%
4	Brazil Bovespa 19.7%	Japan Nikkei 225 -4.1%	Japan Nikkei 225 23.4%	Germany DAX 15.6%	UK FTSE 100 14.2%	UK FTSE 100 -1.5%	Germany DAX 24.3%	China SSE Composite 15.6%	UK FTSE 100 37.0%	USA S&P 500 14.7%	Brazil Bovespa 13.2%
5	Japan Nikkei 225 13.9%	Hong Kong Hang Seng -7.1%	Brazil Bovespa 22.9%	India Nifty 50 14.8%	Germany DAX 8.9%	Hong Kong Hang Seng -5.7%	Japan Nikkei 225 23.3%	Japan Nikkei 225 13.3%	Hong Kong Hang Seng 36.8%	China SSE Composite 14.3%	India Nifty 50 11.5%
6	USA S&P 500 10.6%	UK FTSE 100 -9.3%	UK FTSE 100 20.1%	Hong Kong Hang Seng -1.9%	China SSE Composite 7.6%	Germany DAX -8.4%	India Nifty 50 19.4%	India Nifty 50 8.8%	Japan Nikkei 225 35.1%	UK FTSE 100 10.1%	Mexico MXSE IPC 8.6%
7	UK FTSE 100 10.3%	Mexico MXSE IPC -9.5%	Hong Kong Hang Seng 14.8%	Mexico MXSE IPC -3.8%	Japan Nikkei 225 -3.6%	USA S&P 500 -11.1%	UK FTSE 100 9.7%	UK FTSE 100 7.3%	China SSE Composite 33.1%	Hong Kong Hang Seng 5.8%	UK FTSE 100 8.5%
8	Mexico MXSE IPC 6.6%	Germany DAX -14.1%	India Nifty 50 11.5%	UK FTSE 100 -9.6%	Hong Kong Hang Seng -13.7%	Japan Nikkei 225 -12.4%	China SSE Composite -6.6%	Brazil Bovespa -26.1%	USA S&P 500 22.2%	Germany DAX 3.7%	China SSE Composite 7.4%
9	China SSE Composite 5.2%	China SSE Composite -22.5%	Mexico MXSE IPC 8.7%	Brazil Bovespa -19.7%	Brazil Bovespa -15.0%	China SSE Composite -12.8%	Hong Kong Hang Seng -14.9%	Mexico MXSE IPC -27.2%	India Nifty 50 10.1%	India Nifty 50 -11.2%	Hong Kong Hang Seng 6.5%

Source: Bloomberg. *2026 returns are YTD based on 12 May 2026 closing values. Other years' returns are calculated between the first and the last trading day closing values. Returns are normalized to the Indian rupee. The 10-year return is the compounded average return.

Global equity markets have diverged sharply so far in 2026. Brazil's Bovespa leads the pack, supported by renewed interest in commodities and emerging markets. Among developed peers, Japan stands out, driven by an artificial intel-

ligence (AI)-led technology rally, while the USA continues to post solid gains, underpinned by resilient large-cap performance despite high valuations. In contrast, Germany's DAX has lagged major peers after a strong 2025, and

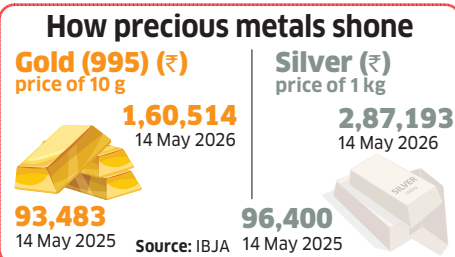
Indian equities rank last, reflecting a phase of correction or consolidation. Meanwhile, Chinese markets are showing early signs of recovery following years of relative underperformance. Over the long term, the US remains the strongest wealth creator,

aided by dominance of big technology firms. Japan ranks second, benefiting from structural reforms. While India has seen phases of outperformance, its decade-long returns remain moderate compared to leading developed markets.

SMART STATS

ET WEALTH TOP 50 STOCKS

The Economic Times Wealth
May 18-24, 2026



Every week we put about 3,000 stocks through four key filters and rate them on a mix of factors. The end result of this is the listing of the top 50 stocks based on the composite rating to help ease your fortune hunt.

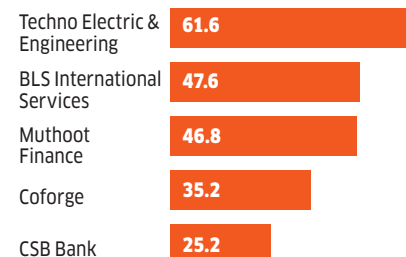
	RANK		PRICE ₹	GROWTH %*		VALUATION RATIOS				RATING	
	Current Rank	Previous Rank	Stock Price	Revenue	Net Profit	PE	PB	PEG (5-year)	Div Yield (%)	No. of funds	Value Research Stock Rating
CSB Bank	1	2	352	25	7	9.6	1.3	0.8	0.0	19	★★★★★
Power Finance Corporation	2	1	451	8	13	5.7	1.1	0.5	3.5	111	★★★★★
City Union Bank	3	5	247	18	18	13.8	1.7	1.5	0.8	43	★★★★★
SBI Cards & Payments Services	4	6	632	10	13	28.0	3.9	1.8	0.4	84	★★★★
R Systems International	5	9	274	18	50	15.9	4.0	0.8	0.0	5	★★★★★
Muthoot Finance	6	7	3,544	47	76	16.3	4.0	1.0	0.7	72	★★★★★
Home First Finance Company	7	12	1,095	25	22	20.7	2.6	0.6	0.5	40	★★★★★
Sundaram Finance	8	10	4,681	13	29	24.8	3.3	2.4	0.8	22	★★★★★
Bank of Maharashtra	9	13	78	17	22	8.7	2.0	0.4	2.8	7	★★★★★
Infosys	10	15	1,095	10	12	15.3	4.9	1.6	4.3	244	★★★★
Coforge	11	3	1,269	35	91	35.1	2.1	1.2	0.9	131	★★★★
Repco Home Finance	12	17	384	5	1	5.3	0.7	1.1	1.0	10	★★★★★
DCB Bank	13	14	180	14	17	8.0	1.0	0.6	0.8	20	★★★★★
AU Small Finance Bank	14	11	1,006	16	25	28.4	3.8	0.9	0.1	57	★★★★★
CIE Automotive India	15	18	456	11	8	20.0	2.3	0.3	1.5	25	★★★★★
Gujarat Pipavav Port	16	22	153	11	39	15.4	3.0	1.2	5.4	9	★★★★★
Mas Financial Services	17	4	323	25	20	15.9	2.0	0.6	0.6	13	★★★★★
Mastek	18	24	1,544	7	7	12.1	1.6	0.8	1.5	7	★★★★
Emami	19	26	425	2	0	23.8	5.8	1.9	2.3	58	★★★★
Hero Motocorp	20	29	5,065	16	31	17.4	4.6	1.5	3.7	107	★★★★★
Gujarat State Fertilizers	21	25	170	7	27	9.9	0.5	0.6	3.0	6	★★★★
PNB Housing Finance	22	27	1,071	11	18	12.1	1.4	1.7	0.8	92	★★★★★
Sonata Software	23	21	266	5	9	16.1	3.9	0.9	2.9	39	★★★★
Affle 3I	24	23	1,497	20	19	47.1	5.9	1.7	0.0	49	★★★★
Glaxosmithkline Pharma	25	33	2,419	2	12	40.0	18.3	1.9	2.2	48	★★★★
Mahindra & Mahindra	26	30	3,163	25	32	22.8	4.2	0.6	1.1	203	★★★★
LTM Limited	27	20	3,953	11	9	23.8	5.0	1.0	1.8	71	★★★★
Chambal Fertilisers & Chemicals	28	32	427	21	18	9.1	1.7	0.9	2.3	14	★★★★
L&T Technology Services	29	34	3,503	13	1	29.0	5.8	1.9	1.7	36	★★★★
VRL Logistics	30	42	245	2	83	18.2	3.7	0.3	3.0	17	★★★★★
Transport Corporation of India	31	44	892	9	13	15.5	2.8	0.5	0.9	7	★★★★
Nippon Life India AMC	32	36	1,090	21	18	45.1	14.8	2.5	2.0	58	★★★★★
Grindwell Norton	33	51	1,792	9	13	47.7	7.8	3.4	1.1	48	★★★★
Jindal Stainless	34	45	744	9	27	19.0	3.1	0.2	0.6	31	★★★★
Hindustan Zinc	35	35	670	20	33	20.6	12.6	2.2	1.6	13	★★★★★
Techno Electric & Engineering	36	46	1,215	62	30	28.5	3.5	1.4	0.7	30	★★★★
Oracle Financial Services	37	48	8,854	12	11	29.3	9.9	3.5	4.5	41	★★★★
Abbott India	38	73	27,490	8	10	37.7	12.3	2.1	2.4	66	★★★★
eClerx Services	39	19	1,533	22	32	20.6	5.7	1.0	0.0	29	★★★★
Esab India	40	47	6,660	10	22	49.0	22.5	1.9	1.3	8	★★★★★
IRCTC	41	52	537	10	15	30.5	9.3	0.6	1.5	24	★★★
Kennametal India	42	37	3,006	18	36	50.1	8.1	1.9	1.3	10	★★★★★
Trent	43	54	4,131	17	11	86.1	21.2	1.2	0.1	134	★★★
Cholamandalam Investment	44	66	1,567	20	22	25.7	4.4	0.9	0.0	131	★★★★★
Indian Energy Exchange	45	56	129	15	15	23.4	8.5	1.2	2.7	35	★★★★★
Vedanta	46	68	337	17	15	7.4	2.6	-	10.5	76	★★★★★
BLS International Services	47	58	260	48	42	17.0	4.8	0.3	0.4	5	★★★★★
Tata Consultancy Services	48	63	2,249	5	1	16.5	7.6	1.6	4.8	156	★★★★
Zydus Lifesciences	49	59	991	17	9	19.9	3.7	1.1	1.2	30	★★★★
Indraprastha Gas	50	55	157	9	27	13.5	1.9	2.1	4.4	25	★★★★

*REVENUE AND EPS FIGURES BASED ON ONE-YEAR GROWTH. DATA AS ON 14 MAY 2026. PERCENTAGES & RATIOS ROUNDED OFF TO ONE DECIMAL PLACE.

SOURCE: VALUE RESEARCH

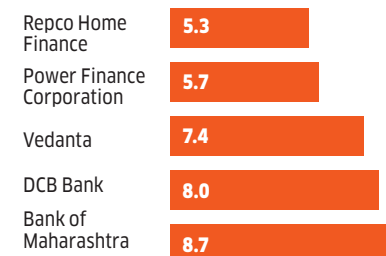
1 Fast growing stocks

Top 5 stocks with the highest revenue (1-year) growth (%)



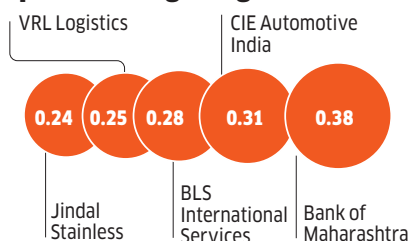
2 Least expensive stocks

Top 5 stocks with the lowest price-to-earnings ratio



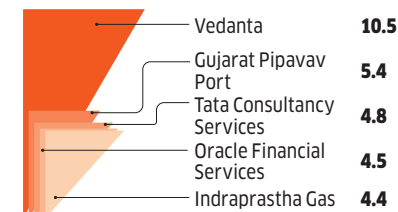
3 Best PEGs

Top 5 stocks with the lowest price earnings-to-growth ratio



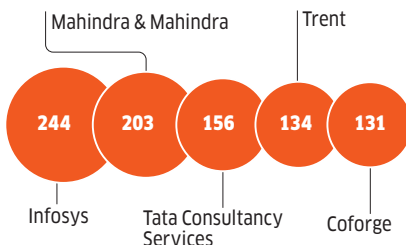
4 Income generators

Top 5 stocks with the highest dividend yield (%)



5 Most widely held

Top 5 stocks held by the most number of mutual funds



STOCKS IN THE ABOVE CATEGORIES ARE SELECTED FROM THE OVERALL TOP-50 STOCKS.

ETW FUNDS 100

BEST FUNDS TO BUILD YOUR PORTFOLIO

ET Wealth collaborates with Value Research to identify the top-performing funds across categories. Equity funds and equity-oriented hybrid funds are ranked on 3-year returns while debt-oriented hybrid and income funds are ranked on 1-year returns.

	Value Research Fund Rating	Net Assets (₹ Cr)	RETURNS (%)					Expense Ratio (%)
			3-Month	6-Month	1-Year	3-Year	5-Year	
EQUITY: LARGE CAP								
HDFC NIFTY50 Equal Weight Index	*****	1,730	-3.9	-3.5	4.6	15.0	–	1.0
DSP Nifty 50 Equal Weight Index	*****	2,523	-3.9	-3.6	4.6	14.9	14.0	1.0
Nippon India Large Cap	*****	51,690	-6.6	-7.5	-0.7	14.4	16.0	3.5
Invesco India Largecap	****	1,722	-4.3	-6.9	0.1	14.4	13.2	2.1
ICICI Prudential Large Cap	*****	75,650	-7.2	-8.9	-2.4	14.1	13.9	1.7
DSP Large Cap	*****	7,192	-6.4	-8.1	-4.7	13.5	11.6	2.5
Bandhan Large Cap	****	2,007	-6.0	-7.3	0.2	13.2	12.4	2.3
Baroda BNP Paribas Large Cap	****	2,579	-4.8	-5.3	-1.1	13.1	12.5	2.0
Tata Large Cap	****	2,688	-5.7	-6.5	-0.5	11.9	11.9	2.0
Kotak Large Cap	****	10,599	-7.9	-8.6	-2.8	11.6	11.5	1.9
Aditya Birla Sun Life Large Cap	****	28,970	-7.6	-9.2	-3.6	11.6	11.7	1.6
HDFC Large Cap	*****	38,121	-8.4	-8.7	-4.0	11.3	12.7	1.9
Canara Robeco Large Cap	****	16,542	-7.6	-9.0	-4.6	11.1	10.8	1.8
Edelweiss Large Cap	****	1,439	-7.4	-8.0	-3.2	11.0	11.4	2.1
SBI Large Cap	****	53,468	-5.3	-5.3	0.2	10.9	11.8	1.5
EQUITY: LARGE & MIDCAP								
Motilal Oswal Large and Midcap	****	16,777	5.9	0.2	12.8	24.6	21.3	1.9
Bandhan Large & Mid Cap	*****	16,672	-0.5	-2.9	8.0	22.2	18.6	2.5
UTI Large & Mid Cap	*****	5,896	-3.5	-4.1	3.7	19.2	16.5	1.9
Nippon India Vision Large & Mid Cap	****	7,081	-3.2	-4.4	2.2	18.3	16.3	1.8
ICICI Prudential Large & Mid Cap	*****	29,757	-5.0	-6.5	1.6	18.0	18.1	2.0
HDFC Large and Mid Cap	****	28,255	-4.0	-6.2	1.8	17.0	16.8	1.6
SBI Large & Midcap	****	38,426	-4.6	-3.9	5.3	15.3	15.8	1.7
EQUITY: FLEXI CAP								
ICICI Prudential Retirement - Pure Equity	*****	1,869	-0.5	-1.2	12.1	23.4	21.7	2.1
Bank of India Flexi Cap	****	2,388	2.9	0.5	10.8	21.3	18.0	3.0
Invesco India Focused	****	5,128	0.0	-6.1	-4.6	21.1	15.8	1.9
ICICI Prudential Focused Equity	*****	16,009	-8.2	-7.8	0.9	18.6	16.7	2.4
Invesco India Flexi Cap	****	4,816	-2.8	-7.3	-0.7	18.0	–	1.9
JM Flexicap	****	5,041	-1.4	-5.2	-2.3	17.9	17.0	2.6
HDFC Flexi Cap	*****	100,479	-7.5	-7.2	-0.6	17.7	18.1	1.3
HSBC Flexi Cap	****	5,405	-0.2	-2.7	4.2	17.5	15.0	2.3
Mahindra Manulife Focused	****	2,208	-4.1	-3.6	1.3	17.0	16.1	2.1
HDFC Focused	*****	26,182	-8.9	-8.3	-2.1	16.8	19.2	1.6
Edelweiss Flexi Cap	****	3,320	-4.4	-4.9	2.5	16.1	14.6	1.9
ICICI Prudential Flexicap	****	20,936	-5.0	-5.9	4.4	15.9	–	1.6
Parag Parikh Flexi Cap	*****	140,949	-2.7	-4.8	0.4	15.7	15.4	1.4
Franklin India Flexi Cap	****	19,049	-7.0	-8.5	-4.4	14.7	14.2	1.7
Canara Robeco Focused	****	2,725	-7.9	-9.5	-1.8	13.3	–	2.1
HDFC Retirement Savings	****	6,733	-7.7	-9.8	-5.1	12.2	14.9	1.9
Franklin India Focused Equity	****	11,488	-8.9	-11.2	-5.5	11.4	12.6	1.9
EQUITY: MID CAP								
Invesco India Mid Cap	****	11,767	-0.7	-2.8	10.4	24.8	20.9	2.2
Nippon India Growth Mid Cap	*****	45,820	-0.2	0.8	10.1	24.3	21.7	1.5
Edelweiss Mid Cap	*****	15,911	0.5	-0.4	8.6	24.1	20.5	1.8
Sundaram Mid Cap	****	13,378	-0.8	-1.7	8.8	23.0	19.7	2.3
HDFC Mid Cap	*****	94,745	-3.2	-3.7	7.7	22.6	20.7	1.4
Kotak Midcap	****	63,539	0.7	-0.7	10.3	20.7	18.5	1.5
Motilal Oswal Midcap	****	35,735	-2.7	-12.8	-8.6	19.5	22.6	1.6
EQUITY: SMALL CAP								
Bandhan Small Cap	*****	25,346	3.6	-0.5	11.1	29.5	22.4	2.0
Invesco India Smallcap	*****	11,038	1.5	-0.5	9.0	23.3	21.6	1.9
Quant Small Cap	****	30,374	8.1	0.2	7.1	20.2	20.1	2.0
Nippon India Small Cap	****	72,673	4.9	0.4	7.7	20.0	21.6	1.4
HDFC Small Cap	****	38,168	-1.9	-7.2	3.8	15.4	18.2	1.6
EQUITY: VALUE ORIENTED								
HSBC Value	****	14,873	-2.8	-2.7	6.0	20.5	18.7	1.7
Axis Value	****	1,523	-3.2	-4.0	5.8	19.8	–	2.6
Nippon India Value	****	8,919	-3.9	-6.0	1.1	19.4	17.2	1.8
ICICI Prudential Value	*****	59,588	-6.6	-8.1	-0.4	16.6	17.0	1.6
SBI Contra	*****	47,352	-5.6	-6.9	-1.4	15.4	18.0	1.5
Bandhan Value	****	9,908	-4.4	-5.6	-0.7	13.8	15.6	2.6

LAGGARDS & LEADERS

Taking a long-term view of fund returns, here is a list of 10 funds in each category—five leaders and five laggards.

LAGGARDS LEADERS

Equity: Large cap 3-year returns

5.0	24.5
Nippon India ETF Nifty 50 Shariah BeES	BHARAT 22 ETF
6.5	24.2
LIC MF BSE Sensex Index	ICICI Prudential BHARAT 22 FOF
6.9	20.1
Tata BSE Sensex Index	ABSL Nifty Next 50 ETF
7.0	20.1
Nippon India Index Fund BSE Sensex Plan	UTI Nifty Next 50 ETF
7.2	20.0
HDFC BSE Sensex Index	ICICI Prudential Nifty Next 50 ETF

15.0%
THE 3-YEAR
RETURN
OF HDFC
NIFTY50
EQUAL
WEIGHT
INDEX
FUND
IS THE
HIGHEST
IN ITS
CATEGORY.

Equity: Flexi cap 3-year returns

1.3	23.4
Samco Flexi Cap	ICICI Pru Retirement - Pure Equity
6.6	21.7
Mirae Asset Focused	Kotak Nifty Alpha 50 ETF
7.5	21.3
UTI Flexi Cap	Bank of India Flexi Cap
7.7	21.1
LIC MF Focused	Invesco India Focused
8.1	18.6
Axis Focused	ITI Flexi Cap

Equity: Mid cap 3-year returns

12.5	26.4
DSP Nifty Midcap 150 Quality 50 Index	HSBC Midcap
12.5	25.7
UTI Nifty Midcap 150 Quality 50 Index	ICICI Prudential Midcap
12.6	25.2
PGIM India Midcap	WhiteOak Capital Mid Cap
13.2	24.8
DSP Nifty Midcap 150 Quality 50 ETF	Invesco India Mid Cap
14.4	24.3
SBI Midcap	Nippon India Growth Mid Cap

23.4%
THE 3-YEAR
RETURN
OF ICICI
PRUDENTIAL
RETIREMENT
FUND - PURE
EQUITY
PLAN IS THE
HIGHEST
IN ITS
CATEGORY.

Equity: Small cap 3-year returns

12.0	29.5
Tata Small Cap	Bandhan Small Cap
12.5	25.5
SBI Small Cap	ITI Small Cap
14.6	24.5
ICICI Prudential Smallcap	ABSL Nifty Smallcap 50 Index
14.8	24.4
Kotak Small Cap	Kotak Nifty Smallcap 50 Index
15.2	24.4
Canara Robeco Small Cap	Axis Nifty Smallcap 50 Index

Hybrid: Aggressive 3-year returns

7.5	22.7
HDFC Hybrid Equity	SBI Children's - Investment Plan
7.8	20.1
LIC MF Unit Linked Insurance	ICICI Pru Retirement - Hybrid Aggressive
8.3	20.0
Axis Children's	BoI Mid & Small Cap Equity & Debt
8.5	16.5
Tata Aggressive Hybrid	ICICI Prudential Equity & Debt
8.8	16.2
PGIM India Aggressive Hybrid Equity	ICICI Prudential Children's

ANNUALISED RETURNS IN % AS ON 13 MAY 2026

ETW FUNDS 100

ETW FUNDS 100	Value Research Fund Rating	Net Assets (₹ Cr)	RETURNS (%)					Expense Ratio (%)
			3-Month	6-Month	1-Year	3-Year	5-Year	
EQUITY: ELSS								
Motilal Oswal ELSS Tax Saver	★★★★★	4,659	9.4	3.0	12.3	23.9	19.6	2.0
SBI ELSS Tax Saver	★★★★★	31,094	-5.4	-5.9	0.0	19.3	17.5	1.6
DSP ELSS Tax Saver	★★★★	16,337	-7.4	-6.9	-2.0	16.3	14.4	1.8
HDFC ELSS Tax Saver	★★★★★	15,559	-8.9	-10.0	-4.5	16.2	17.3	1.7
Franklin India ELSS Tax Saver	★★★★	6,106	-7.6	-9.7	-6.0	14.1	13.6	1.8
Bandhan ELSS Tax Saver	★★★★	6,835	-4.4	-5.2	1.4	12.5	13.5	2.7
Parag Parikh ELSS Tax Saver	★★★★★	5,617	-6.4	-10.0	-6.6	11.3	13.5	1.8
HYBRID: EQUITY SAVINGS								
Kotak Equity Savings	★★★★	10,032	-0.9	-0.6	5.3	10.2	9.8	1.8
DSP Equity Savings	★★★★	3,541	-0.7	-0.7	1.9	9.0	8.1	1.9
ICICI Prudential Equity Savings	★★★★★	16,868	-1.0	-1.1	2.9	7.5	7.2	1.6
HYBRID: AGGRESSIVE (EQUITY-ORIENTED)								
SBI Children's - Investment Plan	★★★★★	6,114	4.8	0.5	14.1	22.7	24.6	3.2
Bank of India Mid & Small Cap Equity & Debt	★★★★	1,482	5.9	5.7	10.3	20.0	17.1	2.9
ICICI Prudential Equity & Debt	★★★★★	50,368	-3.5	-3.6	3.3	16.5	16.9	1.5
ICICI Prudential Children's	★★★★	1,412	-0.7	-3.0	4.1	16.2	14.0	2.8
Edelweiss Aggressive Hybrid	★★★★	3,627	-2.4	-3.5	1.8	14.4	14.1	1.9
Kotak Aggressive Hybrid	★★★★	8,642	-2.5	-2.6	5.2	13.5	12.7	1.8
Mahindra Manulife Aggressive Hybrid	★★★★	2,264	-5.5	-6.7	-1.8	13.5	12.9	2.0
UTI Aggressive Hybrid	★★★★★	6,524	-4.9	-5.3	-0.4	13.3	13.0	1.9
Nippon India Aggressive Hybrid	★★★★	3,958	-4.0	-4.4	1.4	12.6	12.3	2.1
HDFC Children's	★★★★	10,152	-4.8	-7.1	-3.4	9.8	11.7	1.7
HDFC Retirement Savings - Hybrid Equity	★★★★	1,616	-6.9	-8.4	-4.2	9.5	10.6	2.1
HYBRID: CONSERVATIVE (DEBT-ORIENTED)								
SBI Conservative Hybrid	★★★★	9,754	0.7	1.0	5.4	9.2	9.1	1.5
ICICI Prudential Regular Savings	★★★★★	3,289	-0.4	-0.2	4.4	9.3	8.5	1.7
Aditya Birla Sun Life Regular Savings	★★★★	1,479	-0.7	0.0	4.2	8.4	8.1	1.8
Parag Parikh Conservative Hybrid	★★★★★	3,344	-0.2	1.0	4.0	10.2	-	0.6
HDFC Hybrid Debt	★★★★	3,261	-1.8	-1.5	0.1	8.0	8.3	1.7
HYBRID: DYNAMIC ASSET ALLOCATION								
ICICI Prudential Balanced Advantage	★★★★	70,551	-3.2	-2.2	4.2	11.5	10.8	1.4
Aditya Birla Sun Life Balanced Advantage	★★★★	9,182	-2.0	-0.9	3.6	11.5	9.9	1.8
SBI Balanced Advantage	★★★★★	40,732	-2.4	-2.0	3.3	11.6	-	1.5
Nippon India Balanced Advantage	★★★★	9,620	-2.8	-2.9	1.9	10.9	9.8	2.0
HDFC Balanced Advantage	★★★★★	105,378	-4.4	-5.2	0.1	14.6	15.6	1.3
DEBT: FLOATER								
Aditya Birla Sun Life Floating Rate	★★★★★	13,441	1.2	2.4	6.1	7.3	6.4	0.4
DEBT: BANKING AND PSU								
ICICI Prudential Banking & PSU Debt	★★★★★	9,144	0.6	1.5	4.8	6.9	6.2	0.7
Bandhan Banking and PSU	★★★★	12,108	0.9	1.8	4.7	6.6	5.7	0.7
Axis Banking & PSU Debt	★★★★	12,531	0.6	1.5	4.6	6.6	5.7	0.7
DEBT: SHORT TERM								
ICICI Prudential Short Term	★★★★★	21,450	0.8	1.8	5.4	7.1	6.3	1.1
Axis Short Duration	★★★★★	8,955	0.7	1.8	5.2	7.0	6.0	0.9
HDFC Short Term Debt	★★★★★	15,463	0.7	1.7	5.1	7.1	6.1	0.7
SBI Short Term Debt	★★★★	13,746	0.5	1.4	4.7	6.8	5.8	0.9
DEBT: CORPORATE BOND								
ICICI Prudential Corporate Bond	★★★★★	32,682	0.8	1.7	5.2	7.2	6.4	0.6
Axis Corporate Bond	★★★★	8,888	0.6	1.4	4.7	7.0	6.0	1.0
Kotak Corporate Bond	★★★★	16,877	0.4	1.3	4.5	7.0	6.0	0.7
Nippon India Corporate Bond	★★★★	8,246	0.5	1.2	4.3	7.0	6.3	0.8

All equity funds ranked on 3-year returns. Debt funds ranked on 1-year returns. Percentages rounded to one decimal place.

Did not find your fund here? Log on to www.wealth.economictimes.com for an exhaustive list.

Methodology

The Top 100 includes only those funds that have a 5- or 4-star rating from Value Research. The rating of a fund vis-à-vis other funds in its category is determined by subtracting a fund's risk score from its return score. The resulting number is assigned stars according to the following distribution:

- ★★★★★ Top 10%
- ★★★★ Next 22.5%
- ★★★ Middle 35%
- ★★ Next 22.5%
- ★ Bottom 10%

(Not covered in ETW Funds 100 listing)

Debt funds with less than 18-months performance history and equity and hybrid funds with less than three-years performance track record are not rated. This ensures that all the funds have existed long enough to be tracked for consistency of performance. Given the focus on long-term investing, we have considered only the 'growth' plan of funds as it reinvests interim gains unlike 'IDCW' plan which offers periodic payouts to investors, thereby reducing NAV. The fund categories are:

Categories

Equity: Large-cap: Funds investing at least 80% in large cap stocks.

Equity: Large & MidCap: Funds investing at least 35% each in large and mid caps.

Equity: Flexi Cap: Funds investing at least 65% in equity with no particular cap on large, mid or small.

Equity: Mid Cap: Funds investing at least 65% in mid caps.

Equity: Small Cap: Funds investing at least 65% in small caps.

Equity: Value Oriented: Funds following value/contrarian investment strategy and grouped under 'Value' or 'Contra' categories as per SEBI.

ELSS: Equity: With a lock-in of three years and tax benefit under Section 80C.

Hybrid: Aggressive: Funds investing 65-80% in equity, and the rest in debt.

Hybrid: Conservative: Funds investing 10-25% in equity, and the rest in debt.

Hybrid: Equity Savings: Funds investing at least 65% in equity and equity related instruments, and at least 10% in debt.

Hybrid: Dynamic Asset Allocation: Funds which dynamically manage the asset allocation between equity and debt.

Debt: Short Duration: Funds with Macaulay duration between 1 and 3 years at the portfolio level.

Debt: Corporate Bond: Funds investing at least 80% in AA+ and above-rated corporate bonds.

Debt: Banking and PSU: Funds investing at least 80% in the debt instruments of banks, PSUs, public financial institutions and municipal bonds.

Debt: Floater: Funds investing at least 65% in floating-rate instruments.

FUND RAISER

₹1.65 TRILLION

the net inflows into liquid funds in April 2026, which pushed the category AUM to an all-time high of ₹6.36 trillion.

Source: AMFI

1 Top 5 SIPs

Top 5 equity schemes based on 10-year SIP returns

Quant Small Cap

23.4

Nippon India Small Cap

20.9

Nippon India Growth Mid Cap

19.8

Quant ELSS Tax Saver

19.6

Edelweiss Mid Cap

19.6

SIP: SYSTEMATIC INVESTMENT PLAN % ANNUALISED RETURNS AS ON 13 MAY 2026

2 Top 5 SWPs

Top 5 conservative hybrid schemes based on 3-year SWP returns

SBI Children's - Savings Plan

11.5

Parag Parikh Conservative Hybrid

10.6

ABSL Conservative Hybrid Active FoF

10.2

ICICI Prudential Retirement - Hybrid Conservative

10.1

ICICI Prudential Regular Savings

9.3

SWP: SYSTEMATIC WITHDRAWAL PLAN % ANNUALISED RETURNS AS ON 13 MAY 2026

3 Cash holding Thematic: ESG

13.8

Axis ESG Integration Strategy

6.7

Quant ESG Integration Strategy

3.6

Quantum ESG Best In Class Strategy

3.4

Kotak ESG Exclusionary Strategy

2.3

SBI ESG Exclusionary Strategy

% OF ASSETS AS ON 30 APRIL 2026

4 Expense ratio Debt: Medium-to-long

0.61

LIC MF Medium to Long Duration

0.62

ICICI Prudential Diversified Debt Strategy Active FoF

0.82

Franklin India Medium to Long Duration

0.95

ICICI Prudential Bond

1.09

Aditya Birla Sun Life Income

% expense ratio is charged annually. Methodology of Top 100 funds on www.wealth.economictimes.com



Our panel of experts will answer questions related to any aspect of personal finance.

I am 73 and my wife is 69. We do not have medical insurance. Is it possible for our children to create a tax-free medical fund or a dedicated bank account to meet our healthcare expenses? Most private hospitals do not accept Ayushman Bharat. The idea is to maintain an account used exclusively for medical expenses, with no withdrawals for personal use. — Prem Tiwari

While setting aside a dedicated pool for medical expenses is a wise step at this stage of life, it's not a fool-proof shield against them. There are no tax-free medical funds or bank accounts in India that are eligible for a different tax treatment just because they are meant for healthcare. So, you can create a separate savings account earmarked for medical expenses and have your children contribute to it, but from a tax standpoint, it will be treated like any other account. Contributions from children are generally not taxed as income in the hands of parents, but any interest earned on the account will remain taxable as per your applicable slab.

Medical inflation runs around 14% annually which can erode even a well-built corpus in case of a major emergency. This is where health insurance plays a very different role. Beyond just funding, it provides cashless access to treatment. This is particularly valuable in emergencies when liquidity can become a constraint. Even at 69 and 73, senior citizen health plans are available because IRDAI has removed the age cap on purchase of health insurance.



Sarbvir Singh
Joint Group CEO, PB Fintech

I will retire in four years. I have ₹95 lakh in Provident Fund savings and expect ₹20 lakh as gratuity. I have no liabilities. How to invest this corpus to get a monthly income of ₹1 lakh? — Sharad Sharma

With a retirement corpus of roughly ₹1.15 crore, drawing ₹1 lakh a month from this corpus alone is possible for some time, but it is unlikely to be inflation adjusted for life. You should not put the entire corpus into income products. Over a 30-35 year retirement, the bigger risks are inflation and longevity, not just income for today. Even if your current ₹95 lakh from the PF grows at 8% for four years and with ₹20 lakh gratuity, reaches around ₹1.56 crore, a ₹12 lakh annual withdrawal still means a high drawdown rate of about 10.4% on ₹1.15 crore and 7.67% on ₹1.56 crore. The better approach is a bucket strategy: keep 35%-45% in safe income options such as the Senior Citizen Savings Scheme, Post Office MIS, and short-term debt or liquid funds to cover the next 2-3 years of expenses. Put 25%-35% in high-quality debt funds, and keep the remaining 25%-35% in growth-oriented investments such as balanced advantage or conservative hybrid funds. This provides stable cash flow today while helping the portfolio keep pace with inflation over time. A more realistic target from this corpus is about ₹65,000 per month if the corpus stays near ₹1.15 crore, and around ₹87,000 per month if it reaches ₹1.5 crore.



Ravi Kumar TV
Director, Gaining Ground Investment Services

My wife, a homemaker, has never filed her income tax returns but she invests in fixed deposits and mutual funds from her savings. The interest income from FDs and recurring deposits is less than ₹2 lakh. Is it necessary for her to file tax returns? — Vikas Gupta

As per the IT Act, filing an Income Tax Return (ITR) is mandatory only if an individual's gross total income exceeds the basic exemption limit, which is currently ₹3 lakh under the new tax regime (₹2.5 lakh under the old). Since your wife's interest income is below ₹2 lakh, and assuming no realised capital gains from mutual funds, she is not legally required to file an ITR. However, filing a voluntary "nil return" is highly advisable. It helps create a formal financial record, which can be useful for future loan, visa or financial documentation. It also enables her to claim refunds for any TDS deducted by the bank on fixed deposits or savings interest. In addition, regular ITR filing improves financial traceability and can make future compliance or investment-related processes smoother.



Umesh Kumar Jethani
Founder, ApkiReturn

Please send your queries to etwealth@timesofindia.com, mentioning your full name and city of residence.

India hikes fuel prices for the first time in four years

India's state-run refiners have raised fuel prices for the first time in four years, as New Delhi yields to crude prices pushed higher by the war in Iran, and to the resulting financial pressures battering its processors.

Diesel and gasoline prices rose by over 3%, a modest increase in the context of an almost 50% increase in Brent crude since the conflict began.

Diesel will cost ₹90.67 a litre, gasoline will be priced at ₹97.77 a litre in New Delhi. Prices are now the highest since May 2022.

India is the world's third-largest oil importer, heavily dependent on global markets and energy flowing out of the Persian Gulf. In a crisis, the government typically prioritises the protection of its 1.4 billion, price-sensitive consumers and containing inflation, but last Friday's increase suggests it is beginning to restore a balance as fiscal and market pressures grow.

The increase still falls short of expectations for the country's largest state names — Indian Oil, Bharat Petroleum, Hindustan Petroleum — which have been losing ₹10 billion (\$104 million) daily on fuel sales. Fuel retailers will still face a gap of ₹15 to 20 per litre on fuel



sales, said Radhika Piplani, economist at Motilal Oswal Financial Services.

Shares of the refining giants fell in early trading in Mumbai last Friday. Hindustan Petroleum declined as much as 2.9%, while Bharat Petroleum and Indian Oil traded more than 1% lower. On the private side, gasoline is sold at Shell fuel stations at over ₹110 and diesel

at nearly ₹120.

State fuel retailers in India control 90% of the countries' outlets, and are on paper free to set rates. Yet government is a majority shareholder and has kept pump prices frozen since March 2024.

Diesel accounts for about 40% of India's total fuel sales, while gasoline's share is more than 17%. Retail rates vary

from state to state due to the local value added tax. Last Friday's move follows a cut in fuel taxes in March that gave refiners some relief, but will not offset losses. Integrated refiners need world prices closer to \$80-\$85 a barrel to break even, according to Macquarie Research. Brent was trading on last Friday at \$107 per barrel. A modest increase of just ₹3 a litre is partly about containing inflation, already a major concern with a weak rupee and oil above \$100 a barrel. The country's balance of payments may stay in deficit for a third straight year, economists estimate.

It may also be about beginning to prepare the ground for subsequent, and more significant increases, a pattern frequently seen in India. "The hikes are not enough but could be the start of multiple staggered hikes," Madhavi Arora, economist at Emkay Financial Services, said. "Still, we believe ₹5 per litre could have been a good level to start with," she said, adding that oil marketing companies may still face volatility. The market had been anticipating a hike in diesel and gasoline prices after the conclusion of regional elections at the end of last month.

— Bloomberg

Apropos the story on the oil and gas sector, the geopolitical risk premium baked into crude prices today reflects structural vulnerabilities in global supply chains that markets had long underpriced. The article's analysis of upstream beneficiaries versus downstream pressures on OMCs is sharp and timely. What deserves more attention, though, is the consumer angle. A transparent, rules-based pricing mechanism would serve both companies and consumers far better than repeated policy discretion.

K. P. Muthukumar

With respect to the story on delayed health insurance claim submissions, the Bombay High Court ruling reinforces something the insurance regulator has been trying to communicate for years—procedural timelines cannot override legitimate claims. The Menon case is instructive precisely because it was straightforward—expenses were genuine, coverage was valid, and only the submission window was missed. Yet, the insurer fought it. That pattern suggests the problem is less regulatory ambiguity and more institutional incen-

EVs need to pick up pace

The cover story on the energy bill shock is timely and provides excellent information, particularly as crude prices have skyrocketed due to the war started by Israel and the US against Iran. It is the right time to switch to EVs, thereby reducing not only fuel consumption but also environmental damage. Though the union and several state governments have introduced various incentives, the response has been rather lukewarm compared to other countries, as people are hesitant about the supporting infrastructure like charging stations and high cost of replacing batteries.

Hemanth D. Pai



tive to reject. Unless insurers face consequences for frivolous repudiations, rulings like this will remain exceptions rather than the norm. Policyholders must also know their escalation rights far earlier than most do.

Pon. Arunkumar



The comparison between bundled travel insurance versus a standalone policy in the story 'Which travel cover works for you?' is timely, given the sharp rise in international travel and flight disruptions.

The author correctly identifies that most

platform-bundled covers are trip-linked, not traveller-linked. For short domestic trips, bundled cancellation cover is often adequate. But for multi-city international itineraries involving separate hotel and flight bookings, a standalone policy with comprehensive medical cover is prudent.

Prajesh Paramasivan

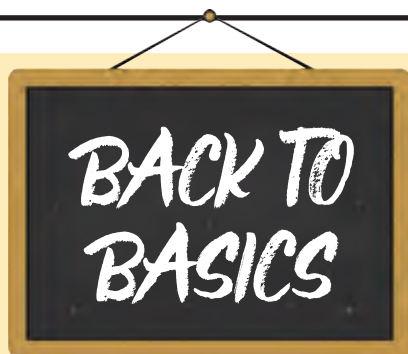
Devashish Chakravarty's framing of reputation as a parallel career in his column is something most professionals intuitively understand but rarely act on deliberately. The invisible interview analogy is particularly apt—hiring decisions are heavily shaped by what circulates through professional networks long before any formal process begins.

Swathi Senthilkumar

The TrendMap's 10-year performance table is a useful corrective to the recency bias that drives most retail investment decisions. Micro caps topping the charts in 2026 will inevitably attract fresh inflows, often from investors who sat out the earlier accumulation phase and are now chasing momentum.

Abbharna Barathi

Please send your feedback to
etwealth@timesofindia.com



What's a yield curve?

If you are confused by personal finance terms, jargon and calculations, here's a series to simplify and deconstruct these for you. In the 103rd part of this series, **Riju Mehta** explains the meaning and types of a yield curve.

Yield curve

It's a graphical representation of the yield (interest rate) changes in debt instruments of the same credit quality but varying maturities. In India, it's mainly used to map out a bond's yield for varying maturities. In the graph, the Y axis represents the bond's yield and the X axis shows the time to maturity.

Types of yield curves

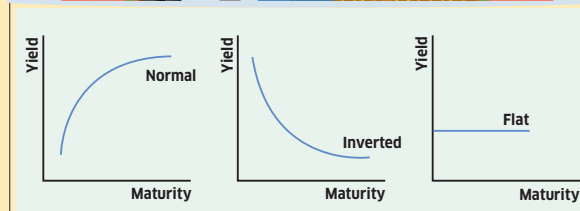
Yield curves are usually of three types—normal, flat and inverted—depending on the varying slopes of the curves.

Normal: It's referred to as normal curve because it's the most common curve shape. Usually, short-term bonds have lower yields and bonds with longer maturity periods offer higher yields because higher risk over an extended period is rewarded with a higher interest

rate. Hence, it's an upward curving graph from left to right, which indicates that investors expect a positive market outlook, with the economy growing at a regular pace.

Flat: As the name suggests, this yield curve is flat which means that there is little difference in the interest rates or yields of short-term and long-term bonds. This may indicate a flat or stable market, where investors don't expect too many changes in the economic and market outlook.

Inverted: An inverted curve shows the reverse yield behaviour, where the short-term bonds offer higher yields and long-term bonds provide lower yields as opposed to the normal curve. The downward graph points at a poor market outlook, with indications of a rise in inflation and a fall in economic growth. This yield curve could also signal



an approaching recession.

Uses for investors

Investment decisions: A yield curve can be used as a predictor for future interest rate movements of debt instruments, and can subsequently help in taking investing decisions based on their existing investments.

Portfolio diversification: Since long-term bonds generally offer higher yields at a greater risk, and short-term bonds offer lower yields at a lower risk, investors can balance risk and reward by picking a mix of short- and long-term instruments. This can help in the diversification of their investment portfolios.

Economic outlook: Since the interest rate movements can indicate market and economic outlook, yield curves can be used as predictors for rise or fall in inflation and the future economic growth or downturn.

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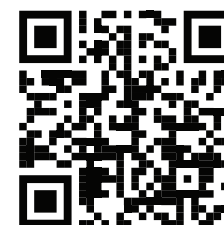
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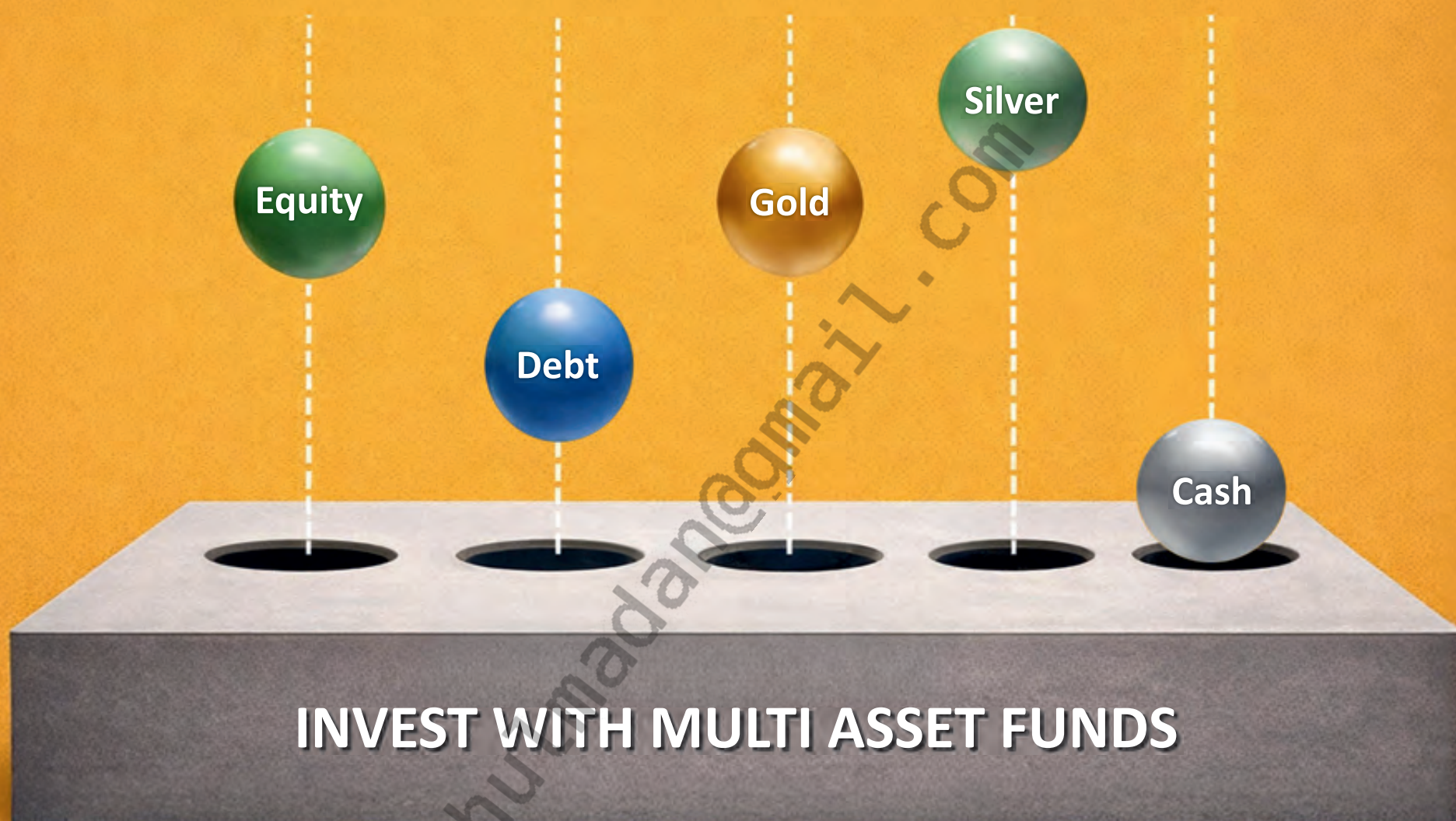
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